Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Matthew

Matthew 1:1

- a record of the ancestors: This phrase introduces 1:1–17. A similar phrase appears in Genesis to start each section of that book.
- Jesus ... David ... Abraham: These names repeat in reverse order in the list of Jesus' ancestors. This is a literary form called chiasm (arrangement of elements in mirror-image). Identifying Jesus as a descendant of David introduces him as the Messiah (see Matthew 12:23; 22:42–45). The link to Abraham emphasizes God's promise to Israel and how the covenant (agreement) extends to include all nations (see Matthew 28:16–20; Genesis 12:3).

Matthew 1:1–2.23

This story shows how certain parts of the life of Jesus fulfilled Old Testament prophecies. This includes:

- his family history and birth (chapter 1), and
- the places he lived as a child (chapter 2).

The story also shows how efforts to stop the plan of God do not work (2:1–15; see also 27:62–66).

Matthew 1:5

Rahab was a Gentile prostitute who risked her life to hide the two spies of Joshua in Jericho (Joshua 2:1–21). Her place in the Messiah's family tree emphasizes the grace of God. She is praised for her faith in Israel's God and her good actions (Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25).

Matthew 1:7

Asa (Greek Asaph): this likely refers to the Old Testament king (1 Kings 15:9–24; 1 Chronicles 3:10) and not the psalmist Asaph (1 Chronicles 6:39; 25:1–2; Psalms 50, 73–83). Matthew focuses on the family line from David to the Messiah.

Matthew 1:8

father of (or ancestor of): Here this term refers to multiple generations (2 Chronicles 21:1–26:1). The same is true for Josiah (Matthew 1:11) and Shealtiel (1:12). The family line skips Ahaziah, Joash, and Amaziah (2 Kings 8:24; 1 Chronicles 3:11; 2 Chronicles 22:1, 11; 24:27). Perhaps this is because of their connection to Ahab and Jezebel.

Matthew 1:11

father: Josiah was Jehoiachin's grandfather.

Matthew 1:12

Shealtiel: Refer to 1 Chronicles 3:17–19 and Ezra 3:2.

Matthew 1:12–16

The Old Testament is clearly the source for Matthew 1:1–11. Matthew probably also used royal records and oral traditions for 1:12–16.

Matthew 1:16

This family history follows Joseph, who is part of the family line of King David (see also study note on Luke 3:23–38).

Matthew 1:17

Matthew says each time period has fourteen generations. But the first and third periods list only thirteen. A traditional Jewish and Old Testament method would count King David in both the first and second groups. It would include Jesus in the third group.

This suggests Matthew is probably emphasizing the gematria (a system where letters represent numbers). The letters in the Hebrew word dawid (meaning "David") add up to fourteen. Matthew is emphasizing Jesus' credentials as the Messiah (1:1).

Matthew 1:18

- Jesus Christ (literally Jesus the Christ): Christ is not a personal name. Christ is a title that means "Messiah" or "God's chosen one."
- pledged in marriage: In Judaism, engagement (or betrothal) was a permanent relationship (Malachi 2:14). It could only end through legal action. So, by law, Mary was Joseph's wife and he was her husband (see Matthew 1:20; Deuteronomy 22:23–24). This was true even though they had not had sexual relations. Since Mary was a virgin when the Holy Spirit conceived Jesus, it proves Jesus' divine nature.

Matthew 1:19

Joseph was a righteous man. This means he obeyed the law (see Luke 1:6). He reconsidered marrying Mary because it appeared she had committed adultery. He could have cleared his name by publicly accusing Mary. This would have led to her trial and possible execution (Deuteronomy 22:23–27; compare Numbers 5:11–31). Or he could pay a fine and end the engagement (see also Mishnah Sotah 1:1–5). Joseph chose to be kind and decided to end the engagement quietly.

Matthew 1:20

The angel of the Lord told Joseph in a dream (see Matthew 2:12–13, 19, 22) that no one had seduced or harmed Mary. Instead, the baby was conceived by the Holy Spirit (Luke 1:34–35). The Holy Spirit often plays a creative and life-giving role (Genesis 1:2; Ezekiel 37:1–14; John 3:5–8).

Matthew 1:21

- Jesus is the Greek version of the Hebrew name Yeshua, which means "The Lord saves." This name describes his role, that he will save his people from their sins.
- His people may refer to either Israel as a nation (Matthew 2:6) or to the Messiah's people, the church. This includes both Jews and non-Jewish (Gentile) people (4:15–16; 16:18; 28:18–20).

Matthew 1:22–23

Jesus being born from a virgin fulfills Isaiah 7:14. The Hebrew word 'almah can mean "virgin" or "young woman." In the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint), it was translated as parthenos ("virgin"), which Matthew quotes. Matthew sees the 'almah in Isaiah as pointing forward to the Virgin Mary.

Matthew 1:25

- he had no union with her until she gave birth to a Son: this might indicate that Joseph had sexual relations with Mary after Jesus was born. (Some traditions teach that Mary remained a virgin throughout her life.)
- Joseph named him Jesus, showing he accepted the child as his own.

Matthew 2:1

- Bethlehem was King David's hometown (1 Samuel 16:1–13; John 7:42).
- King Herod was also called "Herod the Great." He had a rapid increase in power. He went from being the governor of Galilee to the king of Galilee, Judea, and Samaria. He was king from 37–4 BC. He was very loyal to Rome. He was famous for impressive building projects. This included a major renovation of the Temple in Jerusalem. His rule also included family conflicts, suspicion, and the murder of his own family members and innocent children (Josephus, Antiquities 15.7.1–5; Matthew 2:16–18).

Matthew 2:1–2

The wise men's focus on the star shows they were astrologers. Their knowledge of the Old Testament (possibly Numbers 24:17) suggests they came from Babylonia, where many Jews lived. These men were Gentiles (non-Jewish people), which hints at God accepting Gentiles in his kingdom (Matthew 8:11–12; 15:21–28; 28:16–20).

All through the Gospel, unlikely Gentiles worship the Jewish Messiah, while many Jewish leaders (Herod, the high priests, the teachers of religious law, and the Pharisees) oppose him.

Matthew 2:2

Matthew often describes Jesus as receiving worshipped (Matthew 2:2, 8, 11; 8:2; 9:18; 14:33; 15:25; 20:20; 28:9, 17). In this way, Matthew identifies Jesus as God.

Matthew 2:3

It worried Herod very much because he thought this child might challenge him as King of the Jews.

Matthew 2:4

The leading priests had political and religious influence and mainly served in the temple (see Matthew 21:23). Herod gathered the teachers of religious law because they knew Old Testament prophecies and were often influential Pharisees.

Matthew 2:6

- Bethlehem was a small village. It was important because it was where King David was born. The religious leaders knew from prophecy (Matthew 1:22) that this is where God would cause his Messiah to be born there.
- King David had been a shepherd when he was young. As king, he became the shepherd of Israel (2 Samuel 5:2). Micah 5:2–4 predicts the Messiah as a shepherd (compare Psalm 23:1).

Matthew 2:8–10

God placed the star to guide the wise men to the Messiah (see Numbers 24:17). The details are unclear.

Matthew 2:11

The wise men gave costly gifts of gold, frankincense, and myrrh to the king (see Psalm 72:10–17; Isaiah 60). The idea of three wise men comes from the number of gifts. But the text does not say how many wise men there were.

Matthew 2:13–15

flee to Egypt ... until I tell you: This action fulfills the prophecy in Hosea 11:1 (refer to study note on Matthew 4:1–11; see also Genesis 15:13–16; 46:1–5; Exodus 15:1–21).

Matthew 2:15

Out of Egypt I called My Son: See Hosea 11:1, which refers to when God led the Israelites out of Egypt.

Matthew 2:16

- Put to death all the boys: Herod was famous for his cruelty. He even killed his own son to protect his throne. This led to the saying, "It is safer to be Herod's pig [Greek hus] than his son [Greek huios]." This is because Herod followed Jewish kosher laws.
- two years old and under: Herod estimated the child's age based on the wise men's report.

Matthew 2:18

Ramah was a village near Bethlehem. It is where the patriarch Jacob buried his wife Rachel (Genesis 35:18–20; Jeremiah 31:15–17).

Matthew 2:19

After Herod died: Herod the Great died in 4 BC. Caesar (the Roman emperor) divided his kingdom. Herod's son Archelaus (Matthew 2:22) became ruler of Judea, Samaria, and Idumea. Herod Antipas (14:1–12; Luke 13:31–32) took charge of Galilee and Perea.

Matthew 2:20–21

Jesus returned to Israel to fulfill the prophecy in Hosea 11:1 (see Hosea 2:13–15).

Matthew 2:22

- Archelaus, like his father, ruled with cruelty, injustice, and harshness.
- Joseph moved to Galilee to escape the control of Archelaus. This fulfilled a prophecy (see Matthew 4:12–16).

Matthew 2:23

"He will be called a Nazarene": Matthew connects the name Nazareth with words from the prophets (see Isaiah 11:1, where the Messiah is called a "Branch," [Hebrew netser]; and Judges 13:5, where Samson is called a "Nazirite").

Matthew 3:1

- John the Baptist announced the arrival of Jesus (see Mark 1:1–11; Luke 3:1–22; John 1:6–8, 19–34). John helped people get ready to welcome him (Matt 3:3). John drew large crowds (3:5) and gathered a group of followers (9:14). This group continued for a short time as a movement, even after the Christian church began (see Acts 18:24–28).
- John lived in the Judean wilderness. This was symbolic because the wilderness linked to God giving the law (see Exodus 19:1). It also related to God's final redemption of Israel at the end of time (see Isaiah 40:3).

Matthew 3:2

The prophetic call to return to God means turning away from pride and sin and choosing humble obedience to God (compare Isaiah 1:16–20 and Jeremiah 3:11–22). John's message included specific practical advice (Luke 3:11–14).

Matthew 3:3

Isaiah talked about someone making a path in the desert for God to come back to Israel (Isaiah 40:1–11). John's work got things ready for Jesus to arrive (see Matthew 11:10; compare John 12:41).

Matthew 3:4

John wore the same kind of clothes and ate the same kind of food as Elijah, a prophet who had lived many years before (2 Kings 1:8; Malachi 4:5; Sirach 48:10–11).

Matthew 3:5–6

- John's ministry became so popular that many people from Jerusalem and Judea came to hear him.
- Confessing their sins: Those who listened to John's preaching and turned away from sin were ready to accept the ministry of Jesus (Luke 7:27, 29).
- they were baptized: John's practice of baptism might have started with the Old Testament idea of purification (see Isaiah 1:16; 4:4; Ezekiel 36:25).

Matthew 3:7

- The Pahrisees' name comes from the Hebrew word perushim, which means separated ones or exact interpreters.
- The Sadducees, a group of priests, probably got their name from Zadok the priest (2 Samuel 15:24–29; Ezekiel 44:10–16).

Matthew 3:8

Produce fruit, then, in keeping with repentance: John calls for action and real ethical change. Only talking about it is not enough (see Luke 3:10–14; compare Matthew 5:19–20, 46; 7:21; 23:3).

Matthew 3:9

- Do not presume to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father': Some people had wrong assumptions. They thought that being descendants of Abraham meant they were free from God's judgment.
- A key theme in Matthew is that God will create new children of Abraham. He will include non-Jews (Gentiles) in God's people. He will remove Jews who reject the Messiah (see 8:11–12; 21:43; 22:1–14; 28:16–20; Romans 4:9–25; Galatians 3:6–14, 29).

Matthew 3:11

- One more powerful than I: Even though he was popular and many people continued to follow him, John knew he was less important than the Messiah.
- whose sandals I am not worthy to carry: In Jewish culture, removing and carrying sandals was a task for slaves. Not even a rabbi's disciple would do it.
- with the Holy Spirit and with fire: This happened at Pentecost (see Joel 2:28–29; Acts 2:1–47). This may include the ministry of Jesus, empowered by the Holy Spirit (see Matthew 12:28; Luke 4:14). Fire could mean purification (Zech 13:9) or judgment (Malachi 3:2–3; 4:1; see Isaiah 1:25; 4:4). It is a "Spirit-and-fire baptism." The Messiah completes what John could only start (full judgment and purification).

Matthew 3:12

Farmers used a winnowing fork to throw harvested grain into the air, letting the useless husks (chaff) blow away.

The Messiah's work separates humanity into two groups:

1. the wheat, those who respond and become God's new people; and
2. the chaff, those who refuse to repent (see Matthew 3:8).

Matthew 3:14

John had already admitted (Matthew 3:11–12) that he was less important than the Messiah, so he felt unworthy to baptize him.

Matthew 3:15

"It is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness in this way": This means completing what the Old Testament required or prophesied (for example, Jeremiah 31:31–34). In Matthew, "righteousness" means acting according to God's will (see Matthew 5:20; 6:1, 33; 21:32).

Matthew 3:16

The Spirit of God came down like a dove to anoint Jesus, who would bring salvation. This was similar to a king being anointed with oil at his crowning. The Holy Spirit gave Jesus the strength to achieve God's salvation and defeat Satan (see Matthew 12:18, 28). This same Spirit gives strength to the disciples of Jesus (10:20; Acts 1:8).

Matthew 3:17

- This is My beloved Son (see Psalm 2:7): The title "Son of God" explains the nature and role of Jesus (see Matthew 4:3, 6; 14:33; 16:16; 17:5; 26:63; 27:54; 28:19). In his special relationship with God the Father, Jesus achieves salvation as the faithful and obedient Son.
- in whom I am well pleased: God the Father confirmed his Son's work with words from Isaiah (Isaiah 42:1) and prepared Israel for the work of Jesus.

Matthew 4:1

- Jesus was led by the Spirit: God arranged this test to examine the Messiah's character (see Deuteronomy 8:2).
- to be tempted by the devil: God started this test of character, using the devil's wish to lead Jesus into sin. God tempts no one (James 1:13–14).

Matthew 4:1–11

This story of the temptation of Jesus shows clear parallels between Adam and Jesus. Jesus is the second Adam (see Romans 5:12–19) and the second Israel (Matthew 2:15). Unlike the ancient Israelites, Jesus completed Israel's history by wandering through the desert without sinning. He showed he was the obedient Son of God by defeating Satan in spiritual battle.

Since Jesus faced temptation as a human, he can understand the temptations we encounter (see Hebrews 2:14–18; 4:15). He helps us overcome them as he did (1 Corinthians 10:13).

Matthew 4:2

Forty days and forty nights (see Exodus 24:18; 34:28; 1 Kings 19:8): God tested Israel for forty-years in the wilderness (Exodus 16:35; Deuteronomy 1:3).

Matthew 4:3–4

Jesus refused to use his supernatural power to get food, trusting God to provide it. The people of Israel relentlessly tested God with complaints and disbelief (see Exodus 16). But, Jesus refused to doubt God's faithfulness. Instead, he relied on God to meet his real need. This was the spiritual provision that comes from every word of God.

Matthew 4:5–7

Jesus refused to test God by assuming God would always protect him.

Matthew 4:7

It is also written: Jesus responded to the devil's use of Scripture by emphasizing a more important principle (honoring God) which the devil ignored.

Matthew 4:8–9

- Satan is called "the prince of this world" in John 12:31. He offered Jesus control over all the world's kingdoms and their power. Satan did this to try to stop Jesus from fulfilling God's will.
- Glory means political power and control (for example, Matthew 6:29). Satan planned to tempt Jesus to misuse his divine nature as Son. He wanted to distract him from the path of suffering and obedience that led to the crucifixion.

Matthew 4:11

- Then the devil left Him: Jesus rejected Satan. This points ahead to his later victories over demons (Matthew 12:28), Satan's defeat through the cross (Colossians 2:14–15), and the final victory at the end of time (Romans 16:20; Revelation 12:7–17; 20:2–3, 10).
- Angels had already been part of the Messiah's arrival and protection (Matthew 1:20, 24; 2:13, 19). Now they came and cared for Jesus after his temptation, fulfilling the Old Testament (4:6; see Psalm 91:11–12).

Matthew 4:12

- Herod Antipas was the ruler of Galilee and Perea. He had arrested John the Baptist (see 14:1–12). John was probably working in the area at this time.
- When Jesus heard about this, he left Judea. This was near Perea, where Herod had John arrested. Jesus then went back to Galilee. Jesus left to avoid death before he could finish his mission of revealing God's Kingdom. Like Joseph's escape to Nazareth (Matthew 2:22–23), avoiding danger can also be part of God's plan and fulfill prophecy (4:14–16).

Matthew 4:12–11.1

John the Baptist and the Father announced Jesus as the Messiah (3:13–17). He then endured testing in the wilderness with obedience (4:1–11). After this, the Messiah was ready to begin his work. He first preached the message of the kingdom of God to the people of Galilee.

Matthew 4:13

Capernaum was in Galilee, a region that the religious leaders in Judea and Jerusalem viewed negatively (see John 1:46; 7:41–42, 52). Many people from Judea thought Galileans to be unrefined and poorly spoken (compare Matt 26:73). The leaders believed these people could make their teachings less accurate. Galilee also had more non-Jewish people than Judea.

Matthew 4:17

Jesus taught that the kingdom of heaven was coming soon and urged people to repent (stop doing what is wrong) in preparation (see Matthew 3:2; 10:7).

Matthew 4:18

Simon, also known as Peter, became the leader of the apostles (see 14:28; 15:15; 16:16) and the representative disciple (14:29–30; 16:15–19, 22–23).

Matthew 4:18–22

The call of the first disciples shows one purpose of the ministry of Jesus: to invite people to follow him with self-denying obedience (compare Matthew 4:17, 23–25).

Matthew 4:19

- Come, follow Me: This meant accepting the beliefs and lifestyle of a teacher as your own (Matthew 16:24; Deuteronomy 5:33; 1 Kings 19:19–21).
- fishers of men: The disciples would help in the saving and judging work of the kingdom of heaven (see Matthew 10:5–15; 13:47–51; Ezekiel 29:4–5; Amos 4:2).

Matthew 4:20–22

They left the boat and their father: To be disciples of Jesus required both commitment and sacrifice from the brothers (see Matthew 8:18–22; 10:38; 16:24; 19:21).

Matthew 4:23

- The Messiah's work focuses on three main activities: teaching ... preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing.
- The synagogues were Jewish places for prayer, study, and discussing Scripture and tradition. They were also the social centers of many Jewish villages. The hypocrisy and hostility of Jewish leaders were obvious in the synagogues (Matthew 6:2, 5; 10:17; 12:9–14; 13:54; 23:6, 34).
- Preaching the gospel involves sharing the message about the kingdom of heaven (9:35; 24:14; 26:13; also Mark 1:1; Romans 1:16). This message often causes hostility (see Matthew 9:32–34; 10:27–28; 13:1–9, 18–23).

Matthew 4:23–25

This summary highlights the main theme of the section (Matthew 4:23–9:38): the work and message of the Messiah. In ancient writings, chapters did not exist. Authors would start and end a section with the same phrase (called an inclusio; see 9:35).

Matthew 4:24–25

- During the time of Jesus, much of Palestine was under Roman control as part of Syria. At that time, Syria could mean the whole eastern Mediterranean coast. Matthew mentions Syria to show how far news of Jesus spread.
- those having seizures: This refers to epilepsy or demonic possession. In 17:15, a person described this way "falls into the fire for into the water," meaning the boy could not control himself.
- The Decapolis was a group of ten cities, mostly east of the Jordan River and southeast of the Sea of Galilee. These included:
- Damascus,
- Raphana,
- Hippos,
- Abila (or Canatha),
- Gadara,
- Scythopolis,
- Pella,
- Dion,
- Gerasa, and
- Philadelphia (Amman).

These cities were mostly Gentile (non-Jewish) and followed Greek culture.

Matthew 5:1–7.29

This is the first of five long teachings in Matthew (see also 9:35–11:1; 13:1–53; 18:1–19:2; 23:1–26:1). The Sermon on the Mount focuses on the Messiah's call for people to become righteousness. Paul considered righteousness to be God's saving actions and a person's status before God. Jesus uses the term to mean moral behavior that obeys God's will, like the apostle James. Righteousness means doing God's will as Jesus reveals it. This "revelation of righteousness" connects the whole sermon.

Matthew 5:3

The poor in spirit (compare Luke 6:20, 24): in the Old Testament, the poor are often shown as very devoted to God because the rich oppress them. This oppression leads them to trust in the Lord for salvation and help, instead of relying on wealth (Matthew 11:5; Psalms 37:14–15; 40:17; 69:28–33; Isaiah 61:1; 66:2).

In both Matthew's and Luke's writings, the "poor" are indeed financially poor, but their trust in God, not their poverty, makes them blessed (Isaiah 57:15; 66:2).

Matthew 5:4

- Those who mourn are the people who felt sad about Israel's spiritual and national condition (see Matthew 23:37–39; Isaiah 61:2–3; Joel 1:8–13; 2:12–13, 18–19; Romans 9:1–5; 1 Corinthians 5:2; James 4:9). It may also include to personal sorrow, whether from sin or tragedy (Mark 16:10; Revelation 18:11, 19).
- will be comforted: The passive voice shows respect for God's holy name. It could also mean God will comfort them (see also Matthew 5:6–7, 9). Comfort will come when God fulfills all his promises (Isaiah 40:1–2; 61:2–3).

Matthew 5:5

- the meek: Jesus almost directly quotes Psalm 37:11 here. In other places, Jesus describes himself in a similar way, contrasting with other teachers (Matthew 11:29). He also avoids pride (Matthew 12:17–21; Matthew 21:5). Jesus shows this trait

through his death on the cross (1 Peter 2:23; 1 Peter 3:9).

- The whole earth could also mean the land, referring to God's promise of land to Abraham and his descendants (Genesis 12:7; Genesis 17:8; see Isaiah 60:21). It might also mean God's rule over the entire earth (Matthew 19:28; Matthew 28:18–20; Psalm 115:16).

Matthew 5:6

- Those who hunger and thirst for righteousness: These are either followers of Jesus whose main purpose in life is to obey him (see Matthew 3:15; 5:10, 20), or they could be people who want justice for everyone (Psalms 11:7; 85:10–12; Isaiah 11:1–4; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:16). They often pray, "Your will be done, on earth" (Matthew 6:10).
- Christ has brought justice and righteousness (Romans 3:21–22; 5:1), and his followers will find satisfaction in it (compare Psalms 42:1–2; 63:1–2).

Matthew 5:7

Jesus emphasized the great importance of being merciful. This means to show kindness to those in need (see Matthew 6:12, 14–15; 9:13; 12:7; 18:23–35; 23:23; 25:31–46). Those who are merciful now will receive God's mercy at the final judgment.

Matthew 5:8

- The pure in heart (see Psalms 24:3–5; 51:7; Isaiah 6:5) differ from those who believed they could please God by following human traditions (see Matthew 23:25–26). Jesus emphasized simple, genuine righteousness from within (see 6:1–24; 15:1–20; 23:23–28; Deuteronomy 6:5).
- They will see God and achieve more than Moses did (see Exodus 33:18–23; 34:5–7; see also Psalm 73:1).

Matthew 5:9

- This teaching likely addressed zealots. These were Jewish revolutionaries who wanted to overthrow Roman rule with violence. The Messiah's kingdom would come through different methods.
- the peacemakers: Jesus was not calling for complete pacifism. Instead, he called for a new kind of action.
- Peace means no hostility and the presence of God's salvation (Leviticus 26:6; 1 Samuel 16:4–5; Isaiah 9:5–6; Zechariah 8:16; Ephesians 2:14; Colossians 1:20). Those who follow Jesus should work for justice, righteousness, reconciliation, and mercy. These should be the effects of God's salvation through Christ (Matthew 5:43–47; Luke 10:5–6).

Matthew 5:10–11

The first followers of Jesus were persecuted by Jewish leaders who were offended by the new teaching of Jesus, which revealed God's truth with authority (see Matthew 10:17–23; 11:2–6; 12:1–8; 15:1–20; 23:34–36). Since then, following Jesus and his teachings has often led to persecution (10:24–25; 2 Timothy 3:12).

Matthew 5:12

- The great ... reward Jesus talks about is not earned by suffering for doing right. It is God's blessing for those who show his grace to others (see Matthew 10:41–42; 20:1–16).
- The ancient prophets are closely connected with the New Testament apostles (see also 13:16–17; 23:29–36; Ephesians 2:20).

Matthew 5:13

- People used salt for a number of reasons:
- to clean and prevent decay (Ezekiel 16:4),
- in making agreements (Leviticus 2:13; Numbers 18:19; see study note on 2 Chronicles 13:5), and
- to flavor food (Job 6:6; Mark 9:50).
- Salt that loses its savor becomes useless or tasteless (see Mark 9:50; Luke 14:34).

Matthew 5:13–16

The good actions of the disciples will positively impact the world, bringing glory to God. Jesus warns them not to do anything that could harm this positive influence.

Matthew 5:14

Light of the world ... city on a hill: How the disciples live will inspire others to live the same way and honor God (see Isaiah 2:2–5; 42:6; 49:6; 51:4; 56:6–8; 60:1–3; Philippians 2:15).

Matthew 5:16

Glorify your Father in heaven: Those who pretend to be religious want people to praise them, but the disciples of Jesus should want people to praise God (see 1 Peter 2:12).

Matthew 5:17

- To abolish would mean to remove and replace the Law of Moses and the writings of the prophets (that

is, the whole Old Testament) as God's revelation of his will.

- until everything is accomplished: This could mean to obey the Old Testament perfectly, complete their teachings, or fulfill their prophecies (see Matthew 1:22; 2:15, 17, 23). Jesus himself embodies everything the Prophets and the Law taught and expected. Now that Christ has arrived, who fulfills these writings, we must understand the Old Testament in relation to him (Luke 24:26, 44).

Matthew 5:19

- The fulfillment of the Law in Christ means that his disciples must obey all of his commands (see Matthew 28:20).
- commandments: This refers to Old Testament commands (5:18) now fulfilled in Christ's teachings (see 5:21–48).
- least in the kingdom of heaven: Jesus may mean that such a person will still enter the kingdom, but only barely and with low status. Another view, based on some Jewish evidence, is that he means eternal exclusion or damnation (compare 8:12, where "those for whom the Kingdom was prepared" are shut out forever).

Matthew 5:20

Unless your righteousness exceeds: The disciples of Jesus need a new kind of righteousness that only he teaches and makes possible. Matthew 5:21–47 shows this and 5:48 summarizes what it is.

This righteousness is different in amount and quality. Jesus is greater than the temple (12:6) and Jonah (12:41). So, the righteousness of his disciples must greatly surpass that of the Jewish religious teachers and Pharisees (see 3:7–9).

Matthew 5:21

it was said to the ancients: The expression refers to the traditional interpretation of the teachers of religious law and Pharisees. Their traditions did not allow murder, but they did allow hatred. The righteous way of life required by Jesus surpasses this attitude. It demands people to live in peace with each other (Matthew 5:23–24). It is not enough to only avoid committing murder (5:22).

Matthew 5:21–47

You have heard ... But I tell you: Jesus contrasts his teachings to six misunderstandings of the law. Each example shows the surpassing righteousness of Jesus. Jesus reveals God's will, which contrasts with human traditions.

Matthew 5:22

- Judgment ... Sanhedrin ... hell: The second and third punishments are more severe than usual in the time of Jesus. This emphasizes the surpassing righteousness of Jesus and his followers (see Matthew 5:20). They did not accept unresolved conflicts or treating other people as unimportant.
- anyone who says to his brother, 'Raca': The Aramaic term reqa' (transliterated as raca) means something like "empty head." This probably means the same thing as cursing someone (literally if you say, 'You fool'; compare James 2:20). Thinking that other people are unimportant is a sin that expresses itself in different ways.

Matthew 5:23–26

Jesus provides two examples of making peace in communities and society.

Matthew 5:27–30

The righteousness of Jesus exposes sin beyond only outward actions. He shows the true purpose of the law.

Matthew 5:29

Hell (Greek Gehenna): Gehenna was the name of a valley outside Jerusalem. Some kings of Judah used this place to worship idols and even offered children as sacrifices by fire (2 Chronicles 28:3; 33:6; Jeremiah 7:31; 32:35). King Josiah eventually destroyed this site (2 Kings 23:10).

In the New Testament, Gehenna refers to the place where God punishes. Jesus taught that unless his followers live with greater righteousness (living in the right way before God), they will not enter God's kingdom (Matthew 5:20). Instead, they will face eternal punishment (5:22; 23:33).

Matthew 5:29–30

If your right eye causes you to sin, gouge it out and throw it away: These vivid images demand a complete rejection of sin. But even extreme actions like self-harm cannot stop a lustful mind. Jesus calls for a greater righteousness that only he can provide.

Matthew 5:31

A certificate of divorce is a document that makes a divorce legal. Evidence shows this document allowed

remarriage. “The essential formula in the notice of divorce is, ‘Lo, you are free to marry any man.’ … The essential formula in a writ of emancipation is, ‘Lo, you are a freedwoman: lo, you belong to yourself’” (Mishnah Gittin 9:3).

Matthew 5:31–32

Jesus challenges how people misuse the Old Testament rules about divorce (see Deuteronomy 24:1–4; compare Matthew 19:3–9). Only following the rules does not make divorce right. Jesus permits divorce only for sexual infidelity and bans casual divorce (see also 1 Corinthians 7:10–11).

Matthew 5:32

- The exception clause allows, but does not require divorce if a spouse is unfaithful (see also Matthew 19:9). Importantly, Jesus does not require death for the guilty person (see Deuteronomy 22:21–22).
- The idea is that if a man divorces his wife for the wrong reasons, he forces her into adultery by making her remarry. This would violate the law.
- he who marries a divorced woman: It is unclear if Jesus means any divorced woman or only those divorced without a valid reason (like unfaithfulness). Jewish divorce law assumed that legitimate divorces allowed remarriage.

Matthew 5:33–37

Jesus explains the Old Testament’s teachings on oaths (Leviticus 19:12; Numbers 30:2–4; Deuteronomy 23:21–23; Psalm 50:14; Zechariah 8:17).

The Pharisees had different levels of commitment for oaths. For example, oaths not mentioning God were less serious. Jesus teaches that everything connects to God. This includes heaven, earth, Jerusalem, my head (see also Matthew 23:16–22). So, breaking any oath disobeys God’s command (see Exodus 20:7).

The main idea is to always be truthful. The teachings of Jesus make a disciple’s simple “yes or no” as serious as an oath. Honest people do not need oaths (James 5:12).

Matthew 5:38–42

The Old Testament allowed fair retribution (payback) (Exodus 21:24–25; Deuteronomy 19:16–21) to keep punishments from being too severe. Yet, Jesus does not allow personal revenge for his disciples. Instead, Jesus teaches finding victory through suffering and the cross (1 Peter 2:23).

Some consider this teaching as a guide for all aspects of life, including politics. Others consider it to apply to personal willingness to give up rights and forgive as God forgives (see Matt 5:48; 18:23–35). Like the servant in Isaiah 50:4–9 and 53:7 (see also Matthew 12:15–21), the followers of Jesus should apply this virtue to honor, possessions, time, or property. True righteousness does not demand its own way.

Matthew 5:41

Forced labor was a humiliating part of Roman rule (see Matthew 27:32). Jesus transformed it into a chance to joyfully serve God. This saying shows that Jesus opposed Jewish revolutionaries, who called for violent resistance (see 5:9).

Matthew 5:42

See Deuteronomy 15:7–11.

Matthew 5:43–47

Hate your enemy: Jesus is not rejecting the Old Testament. Instead, he is correcting a traditional interpretation that was mistaken (see Exodus 23:4–5). The Old Testament never commands people to “hate your enemy.” The closest verses are in Psalm 139:21–22, where hatred is expressed toward God’s enemies.

Matthew 5:45

By loving everyone, the followers of Jesus would not become children of God. Their actions would demonstrate that they are already God’s true children, living according to his nature and will (see Deuteronomy 10:18–19).

Matthew 5:47

If you greet only your brothers: Jews were taught to greet Gentiles (non-Jews) to keep peaceful relations. But such greetings were not the same as those given to “brothers,” meaning fellow Jews.

Matthew 5:48

- This verse connects 5:20–48 as a single unit (see study note on Matthew 4:23–25).
- be perfect: The word “perfect” means maturity, wholeness, and full devotion to God. It describes a complete response to the message of Jesus about the kingdom (19:21; Ephesians 4:13; Philippians 3:15; Colossians 1:28; 4:12; 1 John 4:18). True perfection has love at its center (see Luke 6:36).

Matthew 6:1

- This verse begins the teaching in Matthew 6:2–18. Jesus explains that righteousness (living in line with God's will) should not be done for public recognition. It should be offered as service to God.
- Righteous acts are actions that follow God's way of living. Examples include:
- giving gifts to those in need (6:2–4),
- praying (6:5–15), and
- fasting (6:16–18).

Jesus encourages keeping these actions private to avoid seeking personal praise instead of honoring God (compare 5:16).

Matthew 6:2

- The hypocrites: see study note on Matthew 23:13.
- a trumpet: they would blow these during important ceremonies, like times of public fasts.

Matthew 6:4

Your Father ... will reward you: This is true both now and at the final judgment, which is at the end of history (see Matthew 25:31–46).

Matthew 6:5

When you pray: Jews prayed regularly at 9 am and 3 pm (see Acts 3:1). They often gathered for public prayer. Hypocrites purposely chose public places at these times so everyone would notice them.

Matthew 6:6

Go into your inner room: Jesus is not opposed to group prayer (see Matthew 18:19–20; Luke 11:2–4). He tells his disciples not to use prayer to seek attention.

Matthew 6:7–8

God cannot be persuaded by repeating words over and over. The Lord's Prayer is a simple and authoritative model (Matthew 6:9–13), unlike the lengthy prayers of pagans.

Matthew 6:9

- This is how you should pray: This introduces what is often called the Lord's Prayer. Unlike the long and repeated prayers of pagan worshipers (6:7–8).
- Most Jewish prayers did not call God "Father." But Jesus did so in nearly every prayer. The only exception is his cry on the cross (Mark 15:34).
- hallowed be Your name: This means that God's name should be honored. In the Old Testament, God's name was dishonored when his people sinned (Isaiah 29:22–24; Jeremiah 34:15–16; Ezekiel 39:7; Amos 2:7).

Matthew 6:9–13

The Lord's Prayer is similar to a typical Jewish prayer called the qaddish. Jesus taught this prayer to his disciples as a brief summary of their new faith.

Matthew 6:10

- When the disciples of Jesus pray for God's kingdom to come soon, they are asking for his justice, righteousness, peace, and mercy to be established.
- No one rejecting the will of God can enter God's presence (Matthew 7:21; 12:50; 21:28–32).
- on earth as it is in heaven: This probably refers to all three petitions, not just the third.

Matthew 6:11

Give us this day our daily bread: A disciple can confidently ask God to provide for daily needs. Then the disciple can continue the work of the kingdom without worry (Matthew 6:25–34).

Matthew 6:12

As we also have forgiven (see also Matthew 6:14–15; 18:21–35): Forgiving others shows that a person has repented and received new life from God. This makes our own forgiveness possible. Those who have experienced God's forgiveness will also forgive. Jesus warns that people who refuse to forgive have not understood God's mercy and may not have truly repented.

Matthew 6:13

- And lead us not into temptation: Just as Jesus was tested (Matthew 4:1–11), temptation will test a disciple's character. Jesus encourages prayer for God's help to withstand the test (see 26:41; Psalm 141:4).
- from the evil one: This phrase can also be translated "from evil." The first reading points to Satan, the one who tempts people (see James 1:13). The second reading points to sin in general.
- "for Yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory, forever. Amen": Some later manuscripts add a doxology (a short hymn of praise) at the end of the Lord's Prayer. It was probably taken from 1 Chroni-

cles 29:11–13 and used to shape the prayer for public worship.

Matthew 6:16

People often connect prayer and fasting (Leviticus 23:27–32; Nehemiah 9:1–2; Zechariah 7:3–5; 8:19; Luke 18:12). Before the time of Jesus, some Israelites misused this practice (Isaiah 58:3–12).

Matthew 6:20

Treasures in heaven: For Jews during the time of Jesus, this was a common image. Obeying God's commands was seen as storing up treasures with God. The context (6:19; Luke 12:33) shows that Jesus was mainly referring to acts of charity.

Matthew 6:22

- The eye is the lamp: The eye gives light to the body and helps guide the whole person.
- A "good" eye means a morally healthy outlook. It points to simple and wholehearted devotion to God (6:24). Here, it also means being generous.

Matthew 6:24

The word translated "money" is traditionally translated mammon. This is an Aramaic term for profits or material possessions. God does not tolerate rivals, so Jesus often warns about the danger of gathering wealth (Matthew 13:22; 19:16–30; 26:14–16; 27:3–10; 28:11–15). This can become an idol (see Ephesians 5:5; Colossians 3:5). We must trust God to provide our needs (Matthew 4:3–4; 6:8, 11, 25–34; 7:7–11; 10:9–14; 14:15–21; 15:32–38). The community of disciples should support each other (6:2–4; 10:40–42; 19:21; 23:23–24; 25:31–46; 26:6–13; 27:57–61).

Matthew 6:25–34

Jesus taught people to live without worry by trusting God to provide for them. His disciples abandoned everything (Matthew 4:18–22; 9:9; 10:5–14). Jesus encouraged them that God would provide their needs.

Matthew 6:26

Jesus teaches by moving from lesser to greater: If God the Father cares for the birds (the lesser), he will surely care for his disciples (the greater). Because the disciples are much more valuable to him, they can trust that he will provide for their needs (see also Matthew 10:29–31).

Matthew 6:30

Having little faith comes from not understanding your worth to God and how God's favor protects you.

Matthew 6:32

- Gentiles: This word refers to people who do not know God and do not follow his will (see also Matthew 20:19).
- your heavenly Father knows: Prayer does not give God new information about needs. Prayer shows trust in God to provide what is needed.

Matthew 6:33

Here, Jesus offers a positive alternative to worrying. His disciples should focus on their commitment to God and seek his kingdom through Christ (see Matthew 6:19–24). This should be their main concern.

Matthew 7:1

- Mercy is a key theme in the teachings and actions of Jesus (Matthew 9:9–13; 12:1–7). But Jesus also clearly opposes sin (18:15–20; 23:13–33). Jesus also warns against controlling or condemning others in the name of care. The kind of judgment he forbids is often harsh criticism of small or trivial matters(23:23–24). Only God has the right to judge (James 4:11–12).
- do not judge, or you will be judged: This may refer to God's judgment at the end of time (Matthew 5:7). God evaluates us based on how we treat others (6:12; 18:21–35).

Matthew 7:3–5

Jesus encourages his disciples to serve others instead of condemning them. The contrast of a speck (speck of dust, chip of wood) to a log in the eye is an exaggerated image meant to show the huge difference (see Matthew 5:29; 23:23–24; compare Micah 6:6–8).

Matthew 7:6

- Rabbis often referred to important ideas or Scripture verses as pearls. The mysteries of the kingdom of God (13:11) are holy (see Exodus 29:33; Leviticus 2:3; 22:10–16; Numbers 18:8–10).
- do not give dogs what is holy: Jews often referred to non-Jewish (Gentile) people as dogs or pigs because these animals were ceremonially unclean (Matthew 15:26; Psalm 22:16, 20; Leviticus 11). Some think this means that many Gentiles would not accept the message of the kingdom. Others see it as a warning about sharing the message of the kingdom with

resistant Jewish leaders (see Matthew 5:20; 10:11–14; see also Hebrews 10:29). It could be a warning to unbelievers in general (see Matthew 18:17; see also 1 Corinthians 2:13–16; 2 Peter 2:21–22).

Matthew 7:7–8

This passage teaches persistence in prayer. But Jesus does not say God will fulfill extravagant desires. God's people should seek daily needs and spiritual blessings (Matthew 6:10–11).

Matthew 7:12

The Law and the Prophets: The teachings of Jesus in 5:21–7:6 show the true purpose and way to express the law of Moses. Love is central for the disciples of Jesus (see also Galatians 5:13–14, 18).

Matthew 7:13

- Enter through the narrow gate: This means deciding to obey Jesus as the Messiah. The wide gate and broad road represent the choice not to follow Jesus or his teachings.
- This path leads to destruction. This means being thrown into fire, being kept out of the kingdom of heaven, being banished from the presence of Jesus, and finally being ruined (Matthew 7:19–23, 27).

Matthew 7:13–27

The Sermon on the Mount ends with a call to decide about Jesus and his teachings (see Matthew 4:23; 9:35). Those who hear the message of Jesus about the kingdom must obey him to gain eternal life. Or else, they reject him and God will condemn them. There is no third way (Deuteronomy 30:15–20; Psalm 1; Proverbs 12:28; Jeremiah 21:8).

Matthew 7:14

Only a few people accept the truth shown in Christ (see Matthew 19:23; 20:16; 22:14; see also John 3:19; 6:66–71).

Matthew 7:15–20

False prophets tell people what they want to hear instead of calling them to obey God's will. Deuteronomy 13:1–5 and 18:21–22 provide guidelines to determine if someone is a true prophet. A prophet's words must match with God's word, and a prophet's prophecies must come true.

Jesus explains the first rule. A prophet's actions must match his words to be trustworthy. So, a true prophet's actions will also match God's word. In the same way that fruit shows what kind of tree it comes from, a person's life shows if their inner being is good or not.

Christians should expect false prophets at the end of time (see Matthew 24:11, 24; Acts 20:28–35; Revelation 13:11–18; 16:13; 19:20; 20:10). Christians can avoid these false prophets misleading them. But Christians must be careful and wise (see 1 Corinthians 12:10; 14:29; 1 Thessalonians 5:21; 1 John 4:1–3; Revelation 2:20).

Matthew 7:16–17

Good fruit and bad fruit symbolize moral behavior (see Matthew 3:8, 10; 12:33–37; 13:8; 21:43; Galatians 5:19–23).

Matthew 7:18

Spiritual rebirth is essential to produce the good actions that Jesus demands. Good works come from faith, and they are inseparable (see James 2:14–26).

Matthew 7:21

The will of My Father: The teachings of Jesus show what the will of the Father is (see also 12:50; 21:28–32; Romans 2:13; James 1:22–27).

Matthew 7:22

- On that day: The Old Testament concept behind this idea is the "day of the Lord." On this day, God will save the faithful and condemn those who oppress others (Isaiah 13–14; Joel 2:1–32; Zephaniah 1:14–16). In the teachings of Jesus, this day is when everyone will be judged based on how they respond to him (see Matthew 10:15; 11:20–24; 12:36; 24:19–50; 25:13, 31–46; Acts 17:31; Romans 2:16).
- Neither spiritual gifts or public accomplishments in the name of Jesus will guarantee God's approval. The decisive issue is obedience (Matthew 7:21).

Matthew 7:23

I never knew you: These people were never truly converted, even though they did great works in the name of God. They refused to follow the Father's will as taught by Jesus, and they continued to break Gods commands. Because they never knew Christ, they never learned to do what he commanded.

Matthew 7:24

- A wise person realizes that Jesus fulfills the Old Testament promises. So a wise person willingly obeys Jesus and chooses to live in such a way that leads to blessings (Matthew 5:3–12; 7:13–14).

- built his house on the rock: Building a house directly on rock provides a much stronger foundation than would a dry, sandy riverbed or floodplain (7:26).

Matthew 7:24–27

This entire sermon (Matthew 5:3–7:27) focuses on following the teachings of Jesus by living righteously (5:20). Listening without obedience is like choosing the wide gate and broad way that leads to ruin (James 1:22–25; 2:14–26). A decision is necessary in light of what God has revealed (see Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28, 30).

Matthew 7:25–27

The storm symbolizes God's all-knowing judgment (see Jeremiah 23:19; Ezekiel 1:4).

Matthew 7:28–29

- At first, Jesus began teaching only his disciples (Matthew 5:1). But large crowds soon followed him up the mountainside.
- The teachers of religious law based their authority on Scripture they quoted or on the traditions of earlier scholars. In contrast, Jesus taught with direct authority.

He did quote Scripture in the Sermon on the Mount. Yet his words carried the weight of his own authority as the Messiah (God's chosen one).

Matthew 8:1–9.34

Here, the kingdom of God appears with supernatural power (see Matthew 4:23–25; 11:2–6). It reaches people who were previously excluded from God's blessings. This included:

- non-Jewish people,
- lepers,
- blind people,
- sick women,
- people possessed by demons,
- tax collectors,
- those with long-term bleeding, and
- the dead.

Jesus showed compassion to people in need. But the religious leaders reacted with anger and opposition. Jesus called his followers to respond with faith and to walk in discipleship (living as his learners and followers).

Matthew 8:2

Leprosy refers to various skin diseases. People with leprosy (lepers) were ceremonially unclean and excluded from society. They could only return once they had no symptoms and a priest declared them clean (see Matthew 8:4; Leviticus 14:2–32). Sometimes leprosy was a judgment from God (Numbers 12:9–15; 2 Kings 5:27; 15:5).

Matthew 8:3

Be clean: When Jesus healed lepers, it showed the presence of God's kingdom in him and his work (Matthew 11:2–6).

Matthew 8:4

The healed leper would show everyone that the religious leaders were wrong not to trust the Messiah (Matthew 10:18) or that Jesus followed the law of Moses (5:17).

Matthew 8:5

- Capernaum is on the Sea of Galilee, four kilometers (about two and a half miles) west of where the Jordan River flows out. In the time of Jesus, it was a thriving fishing village. Located at an important crossroads on the Great Trunk Road, it connected Mesopotamia and Egypt. It was an international village. Much of the ministry Jesus did in Galilee happened there (for example, Matthew 4:13; 8:14–17).
- The centurion: He was one of sixty commanders in a legion and led 100 Roman soldiers (see also Mark 15:39; Acts 10:1; 27:1).

Matthew 8:5–13

Jesus once again served people who were pushed aside or rejected. The centurion was a Gentile soldier. Helping him would have caused strong anger from both nationalistic Jews and separatist Jews.

Matthew 8:7

I will go (compare Acts 10:9–35; Galatians 2:11–14): Some scholars interpret this as a question: Should I [a Jew] enter [a Gentile's house, risking impurity] and heal him?

Matthew 8:8–10

The centurion recognized the authority of Jesus. From his own experience, he knew his soldiers quickly obeyed his orders. He realized that God had given Jesus the authority to perform miracles. The centurion's

faith demonstrates that the kingdom of God includes people from all nations (8:11).

Matthew 8:11–12

The coming of Gentiles fulfills Old Testament promises (Isaiah 2:2–3). God promised Abraham that he would be a blessing to many nations, not just the Jewish people (Genesis 18:18). Christ fulfills this promise (Galatians 3:8, 16).

Matthew 8:16

with a word: Jesus showed his powerful authority. His words alone could heal and give life.

Matthew 8:16–17

Jesus has authority to heal every disease and rule over every demon.

Matthew 8:17

He took on our infirmities and carried our diseases: When he took on the sins of humanity, the Messiah also carried our sickness (infirmities and diseases). Diseases exist because sin is in the world. One effect of Jesus taking our sin on the cross is physical healing (1 Peter 2:24). When Jesus healed people and cast out evil spirits, he showed that he is the Messiah (God's chosen one) as Scripture promised (see Matthew 11:2–6; 12:28; 1 Corinthians 11:29–30; James 5:13–16).

Matthew 8:18–22

Jesus once met two people who said they wanted to be his followers. Jesus explained what it really means to follow him. He wanted them to understand that following him required serious commitment.

Matthew 8:19

The teachers of religious law had an honored job. They preserved, learned, and explained the Scriptures to benefit society. People thought the way to God was through them (Matthew 15:13–14; 23:13).

Matthew 8:20

Being a disciple of Jesus is not easy. It requires more than knowing the right things. Following Jesus includes being willing to give up life's normal comforts.

Matthew 8:21

- Another of His disciples: This statement suggests that the teacher in verse 19 was also a disciple. Calling Jesus "Lord" shows a strong commitment to him.
- bury my father: In Judaism, this was a very important religious duty. But Jesus requires complete dedication to him.

Matthew 8:22

Let the dead bury their own dead. Those who opposed Jesus might have seen these words as ignoring the commandment to honor parents (Exodus 20:12). But it actually reinforces the first commandment (Exodus 20:1–3). The authority of Jesus as the Messiah justified this statement. Living for the kingdom of heaven influences normal human life, including family ties and commitments (see Matthew 10:34–39; 12:46–50; 19:29; Zechariah 13:3; Luke 14:26–27).

Matthew 8:23–27

This story continues the theme of true discipleship. In the storm, the disciples had to trust Jesus with their very lives for safety and rescue. Jesus showed that he even has authority over dangerous weather and the sea (see Job 38:8–11; Psalms 29; 65:1–13; 89:9; 107:23–32).

Matthew 8:24

A fierce storm came upon the lake. Sudden strong winds are common on the Sea of Galilee since mountains surround it.

Matthew 8:27

What kind of man is this?: To receive salvation, people must recognize who Jesus is and put their trust in him. At this point, his disciples still did not understand.

Matthew 8:28

demon-possessed ... so violent: When people were possessed by demons, they often became violent. Other signs included:

- fear of the Son of God (Matthew 8:29),
- being unable to speak (9:32; 12:22),
- blindness (12:22),
- seizures (17:15),
- and doing things to hurt themselves (17:15).

When Jesus cast out demons, it showed that the power of God's kingdom had entered human history (12:28).

Matthew 8:28–34

This event focuses on the authorityof Jesus and the cost of being his disciple. Those who have faith, like the Messiah, will experience opposition.

Matthew 8:29

- Those controlled by Satan immediately recognized Jesus as the Son of God (see Mark 1:24). This answered the question asked by the disciples of Jesus when he calmed the storm (Matthew 8:27). In other places, the true nature and identity of Jesus are acknowledged by the Father (3:17; 17:5), Satan (4:3, 6), people (14:33; 16:16; 27:54), and Christ himself (11:27; 24:36; 28:19).
- the appointed time: This phrase points to the final judgment. At that time, God will condemn forever all who oppose him (see Jude 1:6; Revelation 20:10).

Matthew 8:31

The demons could not resist the power of Jesus. They begged to escape their coming destruction.

Matthew 8:32

- The words of Jesus had power to drive out demons.
- died in the waters: This showed that Jesus had begun to defeat the enemy (Matthew 12:28; Luke 10:17–20; Romans 16:20; Colossians 2:15).

Matthew 8:34

The sad part is that people who saw the Son of God's power to save were afraid of change, so they rejected him.

Matthew 9:1

Jesus lived in Capernaum (Mark 2:1). He seems to have moved there from Nazareth after the people of Nazareth rejected him (Matthew 4:13; Luke 4:16–31).

Matthew 9:1–17

There was debate and conflict among Jesus opponents. This included the teachers of the law and the Pharisees (Matthew 9:1–13), and also the disciples of John the Baptist (9:14–17).

Matthew 9:3

This man is blaspheming: Only God can forgive sins (Psalm 103:3; Isaiah 43:25; Jeremiah 50:20). The teachers of religious law failed to understand the mission of Jesus as God's Son who became human (Matthew 3:17; 11:25–27). As God's Messiah (1:1; 11:2–6), Jesus was saving humanity (8:17; 26:26–28).

Matthew 9:5

It may seem easier for Jesus to say, "Your sins are forgiven," since no one can see immediate proof. But it is much harder to heal a paralyzed man so that he can walk. The visible miracle proved that Jesus had the authority to forgive sins. It forced those who saw it to decide what they believed about him.

Matthew 9:6

So that you may know: Jesus performed the miracle to demonstrate his authority and identity as God's Messiah (see Matthew 11:2–6; 12:28).

Matthew 9:8

The crowd responded with fear and admiration because they realized a powerful truth about Jesus. He is truly the Son of God with the authority to forgive sins on earth (9:6).

Matthew 9:9

Another name for the apostle Matthew was Levi (Mark 2:14). He might have had two names, or Jesus might have given him a new name.

Matthew 9:9–13

Jesus, as Lord and Messiah, removed the obstacles that stopped righteous Jews from interacting with people considered ceremonially unclean or sinful.

Matthew 9:10

The Jewish people hated Jewish tax collectors (Matthew 5:46–47; 18:15–20). This was because they worked with Roman rulers. Jews considered them traitors against Israel. Many also considered them ceremonially unclean because of their contact with Gentiles and the images on Roman coins.

Tax collection was a private business. In each area, Rome gave the right to collect taxes to the highest bidder (compare Luke 19:1–10). Collectors kept any money they gathered above their bid. Out of greed, they often used threats to get the money.

Matthew 9:13

- I desire mercy, not sacrifice: Jesus applies this desire of God to eating with sinners. Jesus showed mercy by eating with them. This contrasted with the Pharisees who avoided sinners. They considered their avoidance to symbolize sacrifices.
- Jesus exposed the Pharisees' true spiritual state. The Pharisees considered themselves to be righteous. But they were actually unrighteous and needed the Messiah to save them (Matthew 7:1–5; 8:11–12; 19:30; 20:16; 21:43).

Matthew 9:14

Fast: Fasting was a way to show humility and repentance before God (2 Samuel 12:16–23; Daniel 9:3). It also reminded the nation of their need to repent (Leviticus 16:29–31; Nehemiah 9:1). Some believed fasting would help bring the Messiah more quickly by purifying God's people.

Jesus and his disciples did not fast (Matthew 11:18–19) This was a quiet but clear message: the Messiah had already come (see also 6:16).

Matthew 9:15

- The guests of the bridegroom: John the Baptist described the Messiah and his disciples this way (John 3:29). He used Old Testament images to show who Jesus really was (see Matthew 25:1–13; Isaiah 54:5–6).
- taken away: This is the first prediction Jesus made about his violent death (see Matthew 16:21; 17:12, 22–23; 20:18–19; 26:2, 26–35; Isaiah 53:8).
- then they will fast: Jesus might be talking about the disciples' sadness right after his crucifixion, or their way of living after his death and resurrection (see Acts 9:9; 13:2–3; 14:23; 27:9, 33).

Matthew 9:16–17

These short parables compare the new covenant (the promises between God and his people) that Jesus began (Matthew 6:26–29) with the old covenant. The comparison focuses especially on religious ceremonies like fasting. Jesus completes the law, but he does not cancel it (5:17–20; see Galatians 2:21; 5:4). At the same time, the new covenant brings new practices.

Matthew 9:18

- Place Your hand on her: Placing hands on someone is a visible sign of praying for God's power to help them. It often results in new life or ministries (Matthew 19:13; Numbers 27:18–23; Deuteronomy 34:9).
- The man believed Jesus could raise the dead (see 1 Kings 17:8–24; 2 Kings 4:18–37).

Matthew 9:18–34

Jesus is the Messiah with limitless power. He invites people to trust in him.

Matthew 9:20

- Because of her constant bleeding, the woman was always considered ceremonially unclean. Anyone she touched was also unclean (Leviticus 15:25–30). But when she touched Jesus, instead of making him unclean, she was made clean. This surprising reversal shows the power to heal, redeem, and make holy (see Matthew 14:36; Mark 3:10).
- fringe: The tassels at the bottom of a tunic (Matthew 23:5; Numbers 15:37–41) reminded Jews to obey God's law.

Matthew 9:22

Your faith has healed you (literally has saved you): Her physical healing showed her spiritual salvation (see Matthew 8:17).

Matthew 9:23

the flute players and the noisy crowd: people publicly expressed their sorrow over a family member's death. This happened with music and laments by professional mourners. "Even the poorest in Israel should hire at least two flutes and one wailing woman" (Mishnah Ketubbot 4:4).

Matthew 9:24

The girl had died, but Jesus said she was only asleep. He meant that she would soon be raised to life again (see Isaiah 26:19; John 11:11–14, 25; 1 Thessalonians 4:14).

Matthew 9:27

- Eye diseases were common in ancient times. People often considered blindness as divine punishment (see Exodus 4:11; Deuteronomy 28:28; 2 Kings 6:18; John 9:2–3). The Old Testament prophesies that when the Messiah came he would restore sight to the blind (Matthew 11:4–5; Isaiah 29:18–19; 35:5–6).
- Son of David is a title connected to the Messiah and miraculous healings (see Matthew 1:1; 12:23; 15:22; 20:30–31; 2 Samuel 7:12–16).

Matthew 9:28

Jesus asked the question to encourage the two men to express their faith in him.

Matthew 9:32

Healing the deaf so that they can hear, and the mute so that they can speak, is a sign of the kingdom of God (Matthew 11:4–5; Isaiah 35:5–6).

Matthew 9:32–34

The Messiah's actions inspire faith, surprise, and sometimes mocking rejection.

Matthew 9:35

This verse links to the section that started in Matthew 4:23. Matthew has shown Jesus as the Messiah who teaches, preaches, heals, and expels demons. Jesus calls the people to make a decision to trust in him.

Matthew 9:35–11.1

Jesus expands his ministry (see Matthew 4:23–9:34) by sending his disciples to other people in Israel (10:5–6). The instructions Jesus gives his disciples (10:5–42) emphasizes missionary work and the opposition and challenges they will encounter.

Matthew 9:36

Like sheep without a shepherd: Jesus grieved the failure of the Pharisees to guide the people with care (see Matthew 12:11–12; 18:12). Their constant attacks against him showed their hard-hearted rejection of God. Because of this neglect and mistreatment, the crowds suffered greatly (10:5–6; 15:12–14; 23:4; Zechariah 11:16).

Matthew 9:37–38

- Harvest refers to the great number of people who are ready to hear and respond to God's message (see also Matthew 13:24–30, 36–43; Mark 4:26–29; John 4:35–38; Revelation 14:15–20).
- the Lord of the harvest: God is the true master of the harvest. All ministries are under his call (see Matthew 23:8–10, 13). So Jesus encourages his disciples to pray for God to send out more workers.

Matthew 10:1

- Jesus called his twelve disciples as workers in the harvest (Matthew 9:37–38). Choosing twelve was on purpose, reminding people of the twelve tribes of Israel. Jesus was appointing new leaders for God's new people under his rule as the Messiah (16:18–19; 18:18; 19:28; 21:43).
- Jesus gave them authority (9:6–8; 28:18): Jesus empowered the twelve apostles to perform tasks that Jewish leaders could not do (9:32–34; 10:5–8). Jesus shows his authority to cast out evil spirits (8:28) and to heal in similar ways (4:23; 8:1–9:35).

Matthew 10:2

- The apostles are ambassadors sent by Christ's authority to represent him and complete specific tasks (see Matthew 10:1–8, 40; 28:16–20). The term apostle also refers to Paul (Galatians 1:1).
- first Simon, called Peter: Peter was the first apostle chosen by Jesus (Matthew 4:18–22; 16:17–19). He served as the leader of the apostles (see 19:27; 26:33; Acts 2:14).

Matthew 10:2–4

The New Testament contains four lists of the apostles (see also Mark 3:16–19; Luke 6:14–16; Acts 1:13). These lists are slightly different.

The order of names changes, but the groups remain the same. The main difference is between "Thaddaeus" (10:3; Mark 3:18) and "Judas son of James" (Luke 6:16; Acts 1:13). These may be two names for the same person.

Matthew 10:3

Matthew, the tax collector (see Matthew 9:9), is also known as Levi (Mark 2:14).

Matthew 10:4

- the Zealot: Zealots were militant Jews who believed violence and war could achieve God's will. As a Jewish nationalist, Simon was probably passionate about the law (Acts 22:3–5; Galatians 1:14; Philippians 3:6). The Jewish historian Josephus blamed the Zealot party for the major war with Rome from AD 66–70.
- Iscariot might refer to someone from Kerioth in southern Judea (Joshua 15:25) or from Kerioth in Perea (Jeremiah 48:24).

Matthew 10:5

- Do not go onto the road of the Gentiles: At this time, the mission of Jesus was limited to the Jews (Matthew 15:24). God would reach Gentiles (non-Jewish people) through the Jews (Isaiah 2:2–4; 42:6–7; 49:6; 60:3).
- Jews saw Samaritans as impure Jews (Luke 17:18) because they married gentiles during and after the Assyrian and Babylonian exiles (2 Kings 17:24–41). The tension between Jews and Samaritans grew worse in 128 BC when John Hyrcanus, a Jewish leader, destroyed the Samaritan temple on Mount Gerizim (Josephus, Antiquities 13.9.1).

Matthew 10:6

They are lost because their shepherds (leaders) neglected them (9:36; 15:24).

Matthew 10:7–8

By doing these things in the name and authority of Jesus, the apostles showed that Jesus is the Messiah (see 11:2–6).

Matthew 10:8

Freely you have received; freely give: While payment is not wrong (1 Corinthians 9:3–19; Galatians 6:6; 1 Timothy 5:17), Jesus encouraged the apostles to avoid appearing greedy (see Acts 8:20; 20:33).

Matthew 10:9–10

Jesus' disciples should trust God to provide (6:11, 25–34; 7:7–11). They should avoid greed, which could harm God's reputation. They should also encourage new communities to provide what their leaders need (see 1 Corinthians 9:3–19).

Matthew 10:12

greet its occupants: Greetings meant more than just saying "hello." They often included a blessing for the person receiving it (see Ruth 2:4).

Matthew 10:13

- A worthy home would accept the message about Jesus and the kingdom of heaven (10:37–38; 22:8).
- The disciples' blessing was an offer of salvation. Taking back the blessing was a sign of judgment as the offer was removed.

Matthew 10:14

Shake the dust off your feet: This act was like the actions of a prophet. It came from an Israelite custom: when crossing back into Israel, they would shake off the dust of Gentile lands to show rejection of ungodliness.

For the disciples, the gesture meant rejecting those who opposed God's work (see Acts 18:6). Speaking judgment on those who refuse the message was part of proclaiming the good news about God's kingdom (see Matthew 11:20–24; 13:10–15; 23:37–39; 24:1–36).

Matthew 10:15

- God destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah because of their evil actions (Genesis 18:16–19:29). With the fuller revelation through Jesus Christ, a town that rejected the disciples' message would receive a more severe judgment.
- that town: A whole village or city is responsible when most people reject the message (see Acts 13:45–47, 50–51; 14:1–7). But God will save individuals who trust in him (for example, Lot; see Genesis 19:1–29; 2 Peter 2:6–9).

Matthew 10:16

- Scripture often compares false leaders who exploit people's spiritual weakness, instead of giving proper care, to wolves (Ezekiel 22:27; Zephaniah 3:3; compare Proverbs 28:15).
- be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves: This proverb means to be wise and careful, but not deceitful or violent.

Matthew 10:19–20

Just as God gave Moses a spokesman in Aaron (Exodus 4:10–17), God would also give Jesus disciples the right words at the right time through the Spirit (John 14:26; Acts 4:8).

Matthew 10:21–22

- Jewish people often connected family conflict with the end times (see Matthew 24:9–10). Jesus himself went through such conflict (12:46–50).
- The one who perseveres to the end means those who stay loyal to Jesus, even to death or until he returns (10:23).
- will be saved: Some interpret this as being freed from persecution, like release from prison. But here it refers to eternal salvation for those who stay faithful.

Matthew 10:23

- before the Son of Man comes: Scholars disagree on whether this refers to Christ's second coming for his church or an earlier judgment, specifically the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (see 16:28).
- you will not reach: Jesus might mean "before you have fled through all the towns" or "before you have spread the gospel in all the towns." The focus on persecution in the context (see 10:17–39) supports the first idea. It suggests the towns were like cities of refuge (Numbers 35:9–32). This emphasizes how widely they will reject the message. It means "not until the whole nation has expelled you."

Matthew 10:25

In the time of Jesus, people often called Satan "the prince of demons." The Greek word used is Beelzeboul, which comes from the name of an Old Testament pagan god, Baal-zebul ("lord, the prince"). In the Latin Bible, the name appears as Beelzebub. This form reflects a Hebrew phrase meaning "lord of flies." It was likely a Jewish insult against Baal-zebul (see 2 Kings 1:2).

Matthew 10:28

- The disciples of Jesus should only fear God by obeying him and testifying about him. Unlike human authorities, God's authority and judgment have no limits.
- hell: See study note on Matthew 5:29.

Matthew 10:29–31

God cares for every sparrow. So, the disciples of Jesus, who are more valuable, should not fear. God will take care of them.

Matthew 10:32–33

God accepts those who publicly acknowledge Jesus in times of trial and persecution (Matthew 10:16–25). These verses describe a person's overall way of life, not just a single confession or denial (see 7:13–27). For example, Judas sometimes acknowledged Jesus but was still condemned (26:23–24). Peter denied Jesus (see 26:69–75), but he was restored and saved.

Matthew 10:34

Jesus did bring peace (John 14:27), but not the kind of social or political peace people often expect. Instead, he called people to make a decision about him. This decision would bring a sword, meaning division, even within families (see Matt 8:21–22; 12:46–50; Luke 12:51).

Matthew 10:34–39

Being loyal to Jesus is more important than being loyal to family.

Matthew 10:37–39

The cross was a tool used by the Romans for torture and execution (Matthew 27:27–55). To take up your cross and follow Jesus means loving him more than anything else. It also means being ready to obey him, no matter the physical or social consequences.

Matthew 10:41

- a prophet's reward: This can mean either the same reward a prophet gets or the benefits of a prophet's service.
- a righteous man: This is someone who follows God's law as taught by John the Baptist (Matthew 21:32) and Jesus (see 3:15). This is why God approves of them (13:43, 49; 25:37–46).

Matthew 10:42

One of these little ones: This probably refers to the low social status of most of the disciples of Jesus (see Matthew 5:3; 18:1–5 and 6:5; 23:5–12).

Matthew 11:2

- Herod Antipas arrested John (Matthew 4:12) because John criticized Herod's immoral relationship with Herodias, the wife of his half-brother (14:1–12).
- the works of Christ: These actions showed that Jesus is the Messiah (Christ) (8:1–9:34).

Matthew 11:2–19

This section starts with John the Baptist's doubt. It ends by honoring his faith and his work (Matthew 11:7–19). The people's rejection of John (11:16–19) hints at their future rejection of Jesus.

Matthew 11:2–20.34

This section focuses on two main reactions to Jesus: acceptance and rejection. The first part (Matthew 11:2–12:50) shows Jewish leaders rejecting Jesus, while his disciples are learning to understand and accept him.

Matthew 11:5

The miracles of compassion that Jesus did showed that the kingdom of God had begun (see 12:28; Isaiah 29:18–19; 35:5–6; 61:1). Jesus expected John to realize he was fulfilling Old Testament prophecies.

Matthew 11:6

Who does not fall away on account of Me: Jesus intended that the works mentioned in verse 5 were meant to help John the Baptist and his disciples decide about Jesus. But Jesus knew that some unexpected parts of his ministry would cause people to reject him.

Matthew 11:7

A reed swaying in the wind: This refers to an unstable person. The implied answer to this rhetorical question is "no."

Matthew 11:11

John the Baptist was the greatest person ever to have lived. Yet the least of the followers of Jesus are greater than John because they live in the new covenant of salvation through Jesus (see 4:17). The new covenant refers to God's new agreement with people that came through Jesus. Salvation (being saved from sin and its consequences) comes through death and resurrection of Jesus.

Matthew 11:12

- The kingdom of heaven has been subject to violence: The Greek verb can mean either that the kingdom suffers violence (negative) or that it forcefully advances (positive). In Luke 16:16, a different verb ("preached") makes the statement clearly positive.
- the violent lay claim to it: This phrase can also have either a negative or positive sense. Negatively, it may point to those who opposed John (see Matthew 11:2; 14:1–12) and persecuted the kingdom's messengers. Positively, it may refer to people "forcing their way in" (see Luke 16:16), urgently pressing into the kingdom through radical trust and obedience.

Matthew 11:14–15

He is the Elijah who was to come: John fulfills the Old Testament prophecy about the prophet Elijah's return (Matthew 17:10–13; see Malachi 4:5).

Matthew 11:16–19

John's message was like funeral songs. He lived with strict self-denial, fasting often and not drinking wine (Matthew 11:18; see 3:4). The message of Jesus is more like wedding songs, with feasting and drinking (see 9:9–17). In both cases, the people of this time respond to God's messenger with indifference and rejection.

Matthew 11:18–19

Here Jesus describes how both John and he himself offended the people of that generation.

John lived in the wilderness, eating locusts and honey (Matthew 3:1, 4). People accused him of having a demon.

Jesus, by contrast, ate and drank freely with others. People accused him of being like a rebellious son (see Deuteronomy 21:18–21).

Matthew 11:20–24

The miracles Jesus performed showed he was the Messiah (Matthew 11:5–6). These miracles demanded people to repent (11:20). Those who rejected the Messiah faced great judgment, because Jesus had clearly shown who he is.

Matthew 11:21–24

As Jesus traveled through the villages of Galilee (Korazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum) he revealed more of himself to the people. Because of this greater revelation, their refusal to listen brought a more severe judgment. Jesus compared their judgment to that of the pagan cities Tyre (Isaiah 23; Ezekiel 26:1–28:19), Sidon (Ezekiel 28:20–23), and Sodom (Genesis 18:22–19:29).

Matthew 11:23

Hades: This is the Greek equivalent to the Hebrew term Sheol (see study note on Psalm 6:5).

Matthew 11:25

The wise and learned: The Pharisees and teachers of religious law thought their access to God was guaranteed through their knowledge and practice of the law. The disciples of Jesus were more childlike (see Matthew 21:15–16).

Matthew 11:25–30

This passage is about the small group of people who accept the Messiah and follow his teachings, even though most of their generation does not.

Matthew 11:27

Jesus showed his close relationship with the Father. Everything he said and did came from his unity with his Father (see John 10:14–15; 14:6–7; 15:23–24; 16:15; 17:25–26).

Matthew 11:28

- The heavy burdens were probably caused by the legal demands of the religious teachers and Pharisees (see Matthew 23:4).
- rest: This means spiritual refreshment, either now or in the future (compare 1:21; Hebrews 4:8–11).

Matthew 11:29–30

A yoke, which connects two animals, symbolizes the demands of being a disciple of Jesus. Unlike the "yoke" of religious leaders, the yoke of Jesus is easy and light. This is not because it demands less of a person (see 7:13–14). But it is because the Messiah's power through the Holy Spirit makes it possible (see Acts 15:10; 1 John 5:3).

Israel's spiritual leaders imposed religious demands (see Matthew 23:4; Acts 15:10). This included 613 Old Testament commands and added traditions. Jesus urged those burdened by the Pharisees' rules to come to him (see Matthew 11:28) to find the salvation for which they deeply longed. This call to salvation involves living obediently to the new teachings of Jesus. Jesus invites people to build a relationship with a humble and gentle teacher.

Matthew 12:1

The Sabbath was the seventh day of the week. God intended it to be a day of complete rest according to Old Testament laws (Genesis 2:2–3; Exodus 20:8–11). Christ fulfills the Sabbath (compare Hebrews 4:1–11).

Matthew 12:1–8

This exchange shows the Pharisees' lack of compassion as they placed a heavy burden on others (Matthew 11:29–30).

Matthew 12:1–14

Matthew closely connects the offer of rest Jesus gives (Matthew 11:28–30) with a discussion about the Sabbath. The rest Jesus offers liberates people from human traditions about the Sabbath (see Hebrews 4:1–11). The Pharisees rejected Jesus because they had a commitment to their tradition.

Matthew 12:3–4

Sometimes it was right to suspend ceremonial laws (1 Samuel 21:1–6).

Matthew 12:3–7

The Pharisees did not understand that God designed the Sabbath to benefit people. They made it a heavy burden instead.

Matthew 12:5–6

Priests worked on the Sabbath (Leviticus 24:8–9; Numbers 28:9–10), and the Pharisees did not find this offensive. If the priests' work for the temple on the Sabbath is allowed, then certainly Jesus can do the same because he is greater than the temple (see Matthew 4:23; 9:35; 11:2–6, 20–30).

Matthew 12:7

The Pharisees misunderstood the meaning of the Sabbath. Their view went against Scripture because it ignored the greater principle of mercy.

Matthew 12:8

Jesus is greater than King David, the priests, and the temple. He also rules over the Sabbath.

Matthew 12:9

their synagogue: A separation was developing between Jesus and Judaism (also Matthew 4:23).

Matthew 12:9–14

This second Sabbath controversy criticizes the Pharisees for prioritizing rules over people's needs (see Matthew 12:7, 11–12).

Matthew 12:10

Is it lawful: Jewish teachers of the law said healing on the Sabbath was allowed only if someone's life was in danger. Because the person's life was not in danger, the Pharisees believed that healing was not allowed.

Matthew 12:11–12

They rescued animals but ignored people, which was inconsistent.

Matthew 12:15–21

This summary of the ministry of Jesus explains that Jesus is the Messiah, God's servant who will bring salvation to all nations (see Isaiah 42:1–4).

Matthew 12:18

- This quote is similar to the story of the baptism of Jesus (Matthew 3:13–17).
- Justice (or judgment): This can be good or bad. Here, it probably means something positive (12:20; compare 23:23).

Matthew 12:20

Jesus does not add to people's spiritual burdens. Instead, he gives them forgiveness with compassion and the sustenance (nourishment and strength) they need (see Matthew 11:28–30; 12:1–14).

Matthew 12:22–45

The Pharisees, the teachers of religious law, and many people of his generation rejected the Messiah.

Matthew 12:23

- People were amazed by the miracles Jesus performed (Mark 2:12; 6:51; Luke 2:47; 8:56; 24:22).

- Could this be: The question expected a negative answer. Jesus did not fit their idea of the Messiah, but his miracles made them wonder.

Matthew 12:24

Beelzebul: See study note on Matthew 10:25.

Matthew 12:26

Jesus said in essence, "If I drive out demons by the power of Satan, then Satan is fighting against his own kingdom. That would be foolish for him to do."

Matthew 12:27

your sons: Jesus forced them to think consistently. If Satan's power casts out demons, then the disciples of the Pharisees were just as guilty, since they too cast out demons (see Acts 19:13–16).

Matthew 12:28

The Pharisees were confronted with the kingdom of God and chose to reject it (see Luke 17:20–21; 1 John 3:8). Through his miracles, Jesus showed the power of the kingdom in the present world. But the kingdom will reach its full completion when Christ comes again.

Matthew 12:29

- This parable forced the Pharisees to answer a simple question. Can anyone drive out demons without first controlling Satan's powers and opposing him (see Isaiah 49:24–26; 53:12)?
- ties up the strong man: This points to how Jesus defeated Satan. He overcame him in the wilderness temptation (Matthew 4:1–11), continued to overcome him throughout his ministry (see Luke 10:17–20), and won the final victory at the cross (see Colossians 2:14–15).

Matthew 12:31

The Pharisees accused Jesus of being under the influence of Satan. Jesus explained that he, as the Messiah, cast out demons through the power of the Holy Spirit. In this context, blasphemy against the Holy Spirit can only mean attributing the ministry and exorcisms of Jesus to Satan's power.

Matthew 12:32

God can forgive people who are confused about Jesus calling himself the "Son of Man." But, God will not forgive a person that says the Holy Spirit's work comes from Satan. Today, this is like completely rejecting the conviction of the Holy Spirit about Jesus. This refers to when an unbeliever ultimately rejects the good news about Jesus (see Hebrews 6:4–6; 1 John 5:16–21).

Matthew 12:33–37

Jesus addressed the main issue. The Pharisees did not accept him or believe his work came from God because they were wicked (see 7:15–27).

Matthew 12:36–37

- The careless word, in this context, was the claim that demons empowered Jesus.
- What a person says will either free or condemn them on the day of judgment. What people say shows the true state of their hearts.

Matthew 12:38

See a sign: People expected the Messiah to perform amazing miracles. This expectation was probably inspired by stories about Moses (Exodus 4:1–9; see also Isaiah 7:11, 14; 38:7–8). They believed the Messiah would show these miracles on demand (see Matthew 16:1–4; Luke 23:8; John 2:18; 4:48; 6:30; 7:31; 9:16; 11:47; 1 Corinthians 1:22).

Matthew 12:39–40

- To demand a sign shows a lack of faith.
- The sign of the prophet Jonah was his "resurrection" from the large fish after three days and nights. It also referred to his preaching (12:41; Luke 11:32). This was similar to the burial, resurrection, and preaching of Jesus. Jesus compared Jonah's experience to what he would experience. He was not predicting the exact timing of his death and resurrection.
- Heart of the earth is another way of saying "the grave."

Matthew 12:41–42

One greater: Jesus is greater than the temple (Matthew 12:6), the prophet Jonah, and King Solomon. So, rejecting him brings more severe judgment on this "wicked and adulterous generation" (12:39).

Matthew 12:42

The Queen of the South: see 1 Kings 10:1–13.

Matthew 12:43

People believed demons liked the dry desert (see Revelation 18:2; compare Isaiah 13:21; 34:14).

Matthew 12:43–45

The Messiah came in victory over evil spirits. But instead of turning back to God, the nation as a whole rejected him. Jesus said that when an evil spirit is cast out, it may return if the person is not ready to resist it. In the same way, judgment would come on this evil generation because they rejected the Messiah (God's chosen one).

Matthew 12:48–50

Those who are true members in the family of Jesus obey the will of God. They show this obedience by obeying the commands of Jesus (see Matthew 7:21). Obedience does not earn entrance into this family, but a person cannot be a member of this family if they do not obey him (see 3:15; 5:17–48; 6:10, 12; 7:13–27; 21:31).

Matthew 13:1–53

In the third major speech recorded by Matthew (see study note on Matthew 5:1–7:29), Jesus here recognized the separation of his followers from others (Matthew 13:14, 16). He began to reveal the secrets of the kingdom of heaven privately to them through parables.

Matthew 13:3–9

- This parable (explained in Matthew 13:18–23) discusses the mostly negative reactions of the Jewish people to Jesus and his message.
- Parables (Greek parabolē): These are stories that use everyday life to explain a spiritual truth. To understand a parable, find the main comparison (analogy) and consider its historical and gospel context. Then a person can understand the main message. Avoid finding unintended symbolic meanings in every part of a parable.

Matthew 13:10

- From this point on, Jesus rarely taught the general public. Instead, he focused on teaching those who had committed themselves to him (Matthew 13:1–20:34). But he would once again confront Israel (21:1–23:39).
- The people were the unbelieving opponents mentioned again in 13:11 ("them") and 13:12 ("whoever does not have").

Matthew 13:11

- The knowledge ... has been given to you: God allowed the disciples to understand the importance of Jesus. God also allowed them to respond to the message of Jesus about the kingdom of heaven with faith and obedience (see 13:19, 23).
- the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven: Salvation is available through Jesus as the fulfillment of Old Testament promises.

Matthew 13:11–15

Jesus answered the disciples question in verse 10. He told them that the Jews' stubborn disbelief and rejection of him brought God's condemnation.

Matthew 13:13

- Jesus told parables, and those who believed him understood them. Yet, those who rejected Jesus found that his parables increased their disbelief.
- Though seeing, they do not see ... hear or understand: They lacked the faith to recognize the truth (Matthew 13:19, 23) and respond (Mark 8:18; John 12:40; see also Jeremiah 5:21).

Matthew 13:14–15

Similar to the message of the prophet Isaiah, the message of Jesus has two effects:

1. It judges those who do not believe or obey, and
2. it creates a small group of faithful people who do the Lord's will (Matthew 21:43).

Matthew 13:16–17

Jesus fulfilled what the prophets and Old Testament believers wanted to see and hear. He fulfills the Old Testament promises (see Isaiah 52:15; John 8:56; 1 Peter 1:10).

Matthew 13:19

Does not understand it: Responding to God's message directly relates to understanding its importance.

Matthew 13:20–21

Has no root, he remains for only a season: The issue is a lack of enduring faith and obedience (see Matthew 7:13–27; 10:22), especially when confronted by persecution.

Matthew 13:22

Jesus talked about the competing demands in life (see also Matthew 8:18–22). The worries of life can become overwhelming and lead people away from faithful obedience (see 6:19–34). The temptation of wealth, especially its deceptive nature, is a common theme in Matthew (for example, 4:8–10; 6:24; 13:44–45). God

values faith, obedience, and helping those in need more than wealth (for example, 19:21; 25:31–46).

Matthew 13:23

Produces a crop: This probably refers to faithfully obeying the commands of Jesus (for example, Matthew 5:1–7:27; 28:20).

Matthew 13:24–30

Matthew 13:36–43 explains this story.

Matthew 13:25

Weeds, also known as tares or bearded darnel, look a lot like wheat. Farmers waited until the plants grew to tell them apart. Intentionally contaminating crops like this was against the law.

Matthew 13:28–30

Jesus rebuked the sons of Zebedee for wanting to destroy villages that did not believe in him (Luke 9:54–55). He told his disciples not to seek revenge against enemies. Judgment is God's responsibility (see Matthew 7:1–5). Jesus urges his disciples to wait patiently for God's righteous judgment ("the harvest"; see Luke 13:6–9).

Matthew 13:31–33

Jesus used surprising and vivid images in these parables. He probably wanted to show how the kingdom of Heaven would grow through preaching the good news. More probably, he wanted to highlight the contrast between small beginnings and a glorious end. He also encouraged the disciples to be patient (see also Matthew 16:24–17:13).

Matthew 13:33

Usually, yeast refers to the influence of evil (for example, 16:6; 1 Corinthians 5:6; Galatians 5:9). But in this context it represents the positive and widespread influence of the kingdom of Heaven.

Matthew 13:34–35

Even the way Jesus taught fulfilled prophecies from the Old Testament. Psalm 78:2–3 talks about sharing the history of God's revelation with future generations. What Jesus revealed in his teachings are the most important part of that history (Matthew 13:10–17; 1 Corinthians 2:7).

Matthew 13:36

- They went into the house (see Matthew 13:1). Jesus taught in public using parables, but he explained their meanings privately to his disciples.
- Explain: The disciples had the special opportunity to learn the secrets of the kingdom (13:11–17). But they did not understand the parables until Jesus explained them.

Matthew 13:36–43

These verses explain the parable from Matthew 13:24–30. The people of the kingdom (like wheat) live side by side with those who do not belong to it (like weeds). The "field" is the world, and this will continue until the end of history.

The mystery of the kingdom is that it is already present in the world, but God has not yet removed the wicked in judgment. The disciples of Jesus must learn patience and trust God's timing.

Matthew 13:38

- The field is the world: The kingdom of heaven includes all nations (Matthew 28:16–20).
- The sons of the kingdom are those who obey Jesus (13:11–17, 23; 21:43).

Matthew 13:40–42

The harvest of judgment, which began with the first coming of the Son of Man (Matthew 3:12) will be completed when he returns (Revelation 14:14–16).

Matthew 13:41

His kingdom: The rule of the Son of Man will be visible over everything at the "end of the age" (Matthew 13:40).

Matthew 13:43

The righteous people will obey God's will as Jesus showed, unlike those "who practice lawlessness" (Matthew 13:41).

Matthew 13:44

- Treasure hidden in a field: People buried treasures to protect them from thieves and military enemies (Matthew 25:25).
- in his joy: Those who find the kingdom of heaven experience more joy from it than any temporary pleasure can offer (see 1 Peter 1:8).

Matthew 13:44–46

Another mystery of the kingdom of heaven (13:11) is that it is more valuable than any treasure. So, a person should give up everything to get it (see 19:21, 29; Philippians 3:7).

Matthew 13:47–50

This parable is about God's judgment on the last day (Matthew 25:31–46). Then he will forever separate the wicked from the righteous. This warning emphasizes the importance of the two earlier invitations to make a decision to trust Jesus.

Matthew 13:49

The wicked are people who do not obey God's will revealed by Jesus. The righteous are those who obey God's will (see Matthew 5:21–48; 6:1, 33; 7:13–27; 12:33–37; 16:27).

Matthew 13:51

Understanding the secrets of the kingdom of heaven is a gift from God (Matthew 13:10–17, 23).

Matthew 13:52

- A teacher of religious law who becomes a disciple in the kingdom of God changes allegiance. He now looks to Jesus as the way of salvation.
- new treasures as well as old: This order shows that the new covenant brought by Jesus takes first place. It is greater than the old covenant that God gave through Abraham and Moses (Matthew 5:17–20; 19:16–22).

Matthew 13:54–58

That Jesus was rejected at home is part of the ongoing theme of the Messiah's rejection by his own people (see chapter Matthew 12; 15:1–20; 16:1–12).

Matthew 13:55–56

carpenter's son: a carpenter (literally, craftsman) worked with his hands in wood, metal, or stone.

Matthew 13:57

They felt very insulted. Focusing on the ordinary social status of Jesus (John 6:42), they missed his unique importance.

Matthew 13:58

To understand the message of Jesus (13:10–17) and experience his miracles, you need faith.

Matthew 14:1

Herod Antipas's official title was tetrarch, which means a ruler of a fourth part of a kingdom. He ruled Galilee and Perea from 4 BC to AD 39 (see Matthew 2:19–22). Jesus called Antipas "that fox" (Luke 13:32). John the Baptist rightly condemned him for adultery (Matthew 14:3–12; Luke 3:19–20).

Matthew 14:2

People were saying that John had been resurrected from the dead (see 16:14).

Matthew 14:3–12

John the Baptist's message drew large crowds, which leaders saw as a political threat (see Josephus, Antiquities 18.5.2). Years after John was executed, many Jews believed that Herod's military defeat by King Aretas in AD 36 was God's judgment for killing an innocent man.

Matthew 14:4

John kept warning Herod about his sin (see Leviticus 18:6; 20:21).

Matthew 14:6

Herodias's daughter was probably Salome. She would have come from Herodias' earlier marriage to Philip. Such sexually suggestive dances were common among corrupt royalty.

Matthew 14:7

Herod Antipas often made extravagant and foolish promises.

Matthew 14:8

In ancient times, presenting a head on a tray was a known practice (see Josephus, Antiquities 13.4.8; 14.15.13; 18.5.1; 20.5.1).

Matthew 14:13–21

What Jesus did consistently fulfilled Old Testament promises about the kingdom of heaven and the Messiah (Matthew 11:5–6; 12:28). Here, Jesus reminded people of God's gift of manna to the Israelites (Exodus 16; see John 6:32). This showed that he is the promised prophet of the end times (see Deuteronomy 18:15–16).

Matthew 14:21

About five thousand men were fed, in addition to women and children: At that time, they counted families by the heads of households, not each person.

Matthew 14:22

After Jesus miraculously fed the crowd, they wanted to make him king (John 6:15). He withdrew from the crowd because it was not the right time.

Matthew 14:22–33

Jesus showed his power over nature, giving the disciples a chance to trust him as the Son of God (Mathhew 14:33; see also 8:23–27; Psalm 8:6; Hebrews 2:8–9).

Matthew 14:23

Jesus often went to quiet places to pray, especially during important times in his life and work (Matthew 26:36–46; Mark 1:35; Luke 5:16; 6:12; 9:28).

Matthew 14:25

- During the fourth watch of the night: This was between 3:00 and 6:00 am by Roman timekeeping.
- Jesus went out ... walking on the sea: This act showed God's rule over the stormy sea (see Job 9:8; Psalm 77:19; Isaiah 43:16).

Matthew 14:27

It is I (literally I am): This statement is associated with the appearance of God himself (see also John 8:24; 18:5–6; compare Exodus 3:14).

Matthew 14:34–36

To understand why Jesus performed miracles, refer to the study notes on Matthew 11:5 and 12:28.

Matthew 15:1

The temple was in Jerusalem, which made it the center of authority in Judaism. This gave these ambassadors from the Pharisees and scribes more influence in their discussions with Jesus.

Matthew 15:1–20

Jesus accused the Pharisees of disobeying God's law because of their focus on preserving traditions.

Matthew 15:2

- Jewish teachers developed long-standing traditions to explain how the written Torah should guide daily life. These traditions were memorized and passed from teacher to student by word of mouth(see 1 Corinthians 11:23; 15:1–5).
- break the tradition of ... wash their hands (see Mark 7:2–4; Luke 11:38): The tradition of hand washing was seen as important. Ignoring this practice was considered disobedience to the Torah and unfaithfulness to God's will for Israel (see Matthew 23:25–26).

Matthew 15:5

A gift devoted to God: The people would probably donate a gift like this at the temple (see Mark 7:11; see also Proverbs 28:24) but it served as a way to avoid financially providing for one's parents.

Matthew 15:6

Nullify: The Pharisees valued their traditions so much that they ignored God's law, turning their devotion into sinful disrespect for God's word.

Matthew 15:7

You hypocrites! See study note on Matthew 23:13.

Matthew 15:11

- What enters his mouth: Jesus may have been speaking about foods that the law did not allow (such as pork or shellfish) or food made unclean by unwashed hands (Matthew 15:20).
- What makes a person defiled also makes them unfit to be with God. Jesus moved the focus from outward rules of purity to the true purity of the heart (see 15:18–19; 23:25–26; Acts 10:1–48; Romans 14:14).
- A person's words show their true character (see Matthew 15:18–20; James 3:1–12).

Matthew 15:13

My heavenly Father has not planted: These Pharisees did not belong to the true people of God (see 3:9–12; Isaiah 5:1–7; Jeremiah 45:4). God will remove them at the final judgment (see Matthew 3:10; 8:12).

Matthew 15:21–28

This encounter brings up another debated issue. It is about whether Gentiles (non-Jews) can share in the kingdom of the Messiah (see Matthew 8:11).

Matthew 15:22

- Canaanite woman: Matthew uses this old expression to describe the woman as a pagan.
- Lord, Son of David: The woman seemed to understand that Jesus was the Messiah (see Matthew 1:1; 9:27; 17:15; 20:30).

Matthew 15:23

Did not answer a word: Jesus stayed silent to test the woman's faith (Matthew 5:28; compare 8:24; 14:16).

Matthew 15:26

Jews often referred to pagans as dogs, which were considered ceremonially unclean (Leviticus 11:27). When Jesus spoke to the woman, he was speaking of her condition as a Gentile. She was seen as ceremonially unclean and separated from God (see Matthew 7:6).

Matthew 15:29–31

- Jesus returned to an area with mostly Gentiles (non-Jews) and performed many miracles. Although God mainly sent Jesus for Israel (Matthew 15:21–28), Jesus also started a new era for Gentile salvation (1:3, 5–6; 2:1–12; 4:12–16; 8:5–13; 15:21–28; 28:16–20).
- These healings show that God's kingdom began with the work of Jesus (8:1–9:34; 11:5–6; 12:28).
- the God of Israel: This suggests that the crowd (15:30) was mostly Gentile.

Matthew 15:32–39

The earlier feeding miracle (see Matthew 14:13–21) was for the Jews. This miracle extended the blessing to the gentiles. It continues the theme found in Matthew 15:27. By this miracle, Jesus showed that he is the true "bread of life" (see 16:5–12; John 6).

Matthew 15:39

Magadan is a place whose location is unknown. It may be the same as Magdala, as some Greek manuscripts say (see also Mark 8:10).

Matthew 16:1–12

After being welcomed among the Gentiles (non-Jews), Jesus returned to his own people. There he faced rejection again.

Matthew 16:2–3

The leaders asked Jesus for a sign from heaven (Matthew 16:1). Jesus made a wordplay with their request. They could read signs in the sky to predict the weather (the Greek word ouranos means both "sky" and "heaven"). But they failed to recognize the Messiah, even though many signs had already been given (see 11:1–6).

Matthew 16:3

The signs of the times were Jesus himself and the miracles he performed (see Matthew 16:4; 11:2–6; 12:28).

Matthew 16:9–10

Jesus had shown his disciples that he is the true "bread of life" (15:32–39; John 6:35, 48). In contrast, the Jewish leaders taught things that were wrong. Their false teaching spread everywhere, like yeast (or leaven) spreads through bread dough (see study note on Matt 16:11–12).

Matthew 16:11–12

Leaven (or yeast) often symbolizes sin and evil (see Exodus 12:8, 15; Leviticus 6:16–17; Galatians 5:9). Here, it represents how deceptive teaching spreads.

Matthew 16:13

Caesarea Philippi was about forty kilometers (twenty-five miles) north of Capernaum. It had many shrines (holy places) dedicated to Pan, the Roman god of nature.

Matthew 16:14

- Some, like Herod Antipas, thought Jesus was John the Baptist raised from the dead (Matthew 14:1–2).
- Others expected Elijah to return before the Messiah came (11:14; 17:10–12; Malachi 3:1; 4:5–6).
- Jeremiah or one of the prophets: Some thought Jesus was Jeremiah or another prophet. Certain Jews believed Jeremiah would rise again (see 2 Maccabees 15:13–16). Because Jesus spoke strongly on sensitive issues (Matthew 5:17; 15:1–20), some thought he was Jeremiah.

At this point, people did not yet understand that Jesus was the Messiah (God's chosen one).

Matthew 16:16

Peter acknowledges Jesus as "the Christ, the Son of the living God" (Matthew 3:17). This showed that God had opened Peter's eyes through faith (see 11:25–27; 14:33; 27:54).

Matthew 16:17

God revealed to Peter his plan for saving people through Jesus, the Messiah. This moment of revelation was key in showing God's will for humanity (see Galatians 1:16; 3:23; Ephesians 3:5).

Matthew 16:18

- In Greek, Peter's name is Petros, which means "rock" or "stone." When Jesus says, on this rock (Greek petra), he is making a play on words between Peter's name (Petros) and the word for rock (petra).

Peter was the foundational "rock" because he was the first to confess Jesus as the Christ and was leader of the apostles. He was the "founding member" of the Church (see Ephesians 2:20–22; Revelation 21:14).
Some scholars think Jesus was talking about himself when he mentioned this rock. But it seems Jesus was referring to Peter or Peter's confession. However, it is clearly the church of Jesus, not of Peter. Jesus himself will build it. So, later church leaders do not need to get their authority from Peter.

- Matthew is the only gospel writer who uses the term "church" (also Matthew 18:17). Here, it means "the community of God's people" rather than the expanded idea of an organized church.
- will not prevail against it: The church will not be defeated by Satan's attacks (see Matthew 11:12; 13:24–30, 36–43).

Matthew 16:19

- Keys symbolize access to special knowledge that gives someone authority (see Matthew 13:16–17; 23:13; Isaiah 22:22; Revelation 3:7).
- bind ... loose: Jesus gave Peter (and later the rest of the twelve apostles, Matthew 18:18) the authority to teach God's will as Jesus Christ revealed it (13:52; 18:15–20; 23:2–12; 28:16–20).
- will be: You could also translate this as will have been. This emphasizes that God's sovereign decision comes first.

Matthew 16:21

- This is the first of three times Jesus told his disciples that he would suffer. He said he would be betrayed, crucified, and killed (see also Matthew 17:22–23; 20:18–19). Each of these predictions also taught a lesson about the cost of following him (see 16:24–27; 20:20–28).
- The suffering of Jesus was part of God's plan and was necessary for the Messiah (see 17:12).

Matthew 16:21–28

Jesus was now officially recognized by his disciples as the Messiah. He then began to reveal a surprising part of his mission. He must suffer before entering his glory (Matthew 16:21–23). Those who follow him will also face suffering (16:24–28).

Matthew 16:22

began to rebuke Him: Peter realized that Jesus was God's Messiah. But he did not understand that the Messiah had to suffer.

Matthew 16:23

- Just as Satan tempted Jesus to take royal privileges without first going to the cross (see Matthew 4:8–10), so now Jesus saw Peter's words as stirred up by satanic forces.
- a stumbling block: This is something that causes a person to fall.

Matthew 16:24

- deny ... take up ... follow: These three commands symbolize an extreme commitment. They mean confessing sins to God with humility, giving personal goals to God, and living by his will (see also Matthew 5:20; 10:34–39; 18:1–5; 20:20–28).
- take up his cross: This is a metaphor for devotion (see Luke 9:23). It is not necessarily a command to die for one's faith, though that is always a possibility for the disciples of Jesus (Matthew 5:10–12; 10:21).
- Matthew uses follow both literally (see Matthew 9:19; 26:58) and as a metaphor. Metaphorically, it shows interest in a teacher (4:25; 8:1, 10; 12:15; 14:13; 19:2; 20:29; 21:9) or personal loyalty to Jesus. This involves him summoning, a response to commit, and significant ongoing struggles (4:20, 22; 8:19, 22–23; 9:9; 10:38; 16:24; 19:21, 27).

Matthew 16:25

The disciples of Jesus need to give up control of their own lives, even being willing to suffer or die for him. Jesus promised that those who follow him in this way may suffer now, but at the final judgment God will show them to be right, clear away every false charge, and welcome them into his kingdom with honor (see 1 Peter 2:23).

Matthew 16:26

His soul: "Soul" and "life" (Matthew 16:25) both translate the same Greek word psuchē. It refers to the essence or being of a person—the self.

Matthew 16:27

The command to deny oneself and follow Jesus has its basis in the fact that Jesus will return to judge all people according to what they have done (see Matthew 19:28; 24:29–31; 25:31; Psalm 62:12; Proverbs 24:12).

Matthew 16:28

- This saying might refer to:

1. the transfiguration that follows (Matthwe 17:1–13);

2. the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ (27:50–53; 28:1–10);
3. Pentecost (Acts 2:1–47);
4. the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (Matt 24:1–31);
5. the future second coming of Christ (24:29–31); or
6. an ongoing revelation of God's kingdom, including worldwide evangelism.

In the fourth view, coming would mean "coming in judgment" on sinful Israel.

- The term Son of Man (16:27–28) creates an inclusio (bracketing expression) with 16:13. This creates a unified section (16:13–28) together around the question of who the Son of Man is. He is the Messiah who would first suffer, then be exalted by God, and finally return as Judge.

Matthew 17:1

- Peter, James, and John later went with Jesus to Gethsemane (Matthew 26:37; 2 Peter 1:16–19).
- We cannot know the exact location of this high mountain. The traditional site, Mount Tabor, is about 580 meters high (1,900 feet). It is not on the way if leaving from Caesarea Philippi (Matthew 16:13) to go to Capernaum (17:24).

Mount Hermon is another option. It is about 2,800 meters high (9,200 feet) and located in Syria, about sixty-four kilometers (forty miles) north of Capernaum. Yet, it is improbable that "scribes" (Mark 9:14) would have gathered at the base of a mountain in non-Jewish territory. A likely location is Mount Meron, about 1,220 meters high (4,000 feet). It is located between Caesarea Philippi and Capernaum.

Matthew 17:2

He was transfigured: In this moment, the inner and divine nature of Jesus, normally hidden, was now revealed. The three disciples were given a glimpse of his glory (see Exodus 34:29–35; Psalm 104:2; 2 Corinthians 3:12–18; Revelation 1:16). All of the disciples of Jesus will share in this glory one day (Matthew 13:43).

Matthew 17:3

Moses represents the law, and Elijah represents the prophets. They appeared as witnesses to Christ. Their presence showed that Jesus, the Son of God, fulfills everything written in the law and the prophets (see Matthew 5:17–20; 11:2–6; 12:28).

Matthew 17:4

Three shelters (Or three tabernacles): Peter probably thought the kingdom of heaven was about to arrive in full glory (compare Acts 1:6). He wanted to remember the moment by building shelters.

Matthew 17:5

- A bright cloud enveloped them: In the Old Testament, a cloud often showed God's presence with Israel during the time of Moses (see Exodus 24:15–18; 25:8; 29:45–46; 40:34–38).
- My beloved Son: This confirmed what Peter had already declared about Jesus (Matthew 16:16–17).
- The disciples were told to listen to Jesus because he is God's Son. As a prophet, he reveals God's will (11:27; see Deuteronomy 18:15, 18; Acts 3:22–23; 7:37).

Matthew 17:6–7

People often react this way when they experience God's glory (for example, Isaiah 6:5; Daniel 8:17; 10:9, 15–19; Revelation 1:17).

Matthew 17:9

People could not fully understand Jesus until he completed his work, especially his death and resurrection.

Matthew 17:10–13

Elijah's appearance made the disciples ask about the belief that Elijah must return before the Messiah comes (see Malachi 4:5–6). Jesus pointed to John the Baptist as the one who fulfilled that role. In doing so, he reminded them of the surprising truth that the Messiah must suffer, just as John, his forerunner, had also suffered (Matthew 14:3–12).

Matthew 17:17

O unbelieving and perverse generation: This phrase often describes moral corruption (see Deuteronomy 32:5, 19–22). Jesus usually directed this exclamation at unbelieving Jewish crowds or leaders who refused to recognize God's presence in him (see Matthew 12:39). But here the phrase sharply criticizes his disciples for not trusting in Jesus and his power to save and heal.

Matthew 17:20

- Here, the phrase so little faith means the same as no faith.
- faith the size of a mustard seed: This suggests that even a tiny amount of faith can help the disciples achieve great things (Hebrews 21:21; compare 1 Corinthians 13:2). It also suggests that if they let their faith increase (see Matthew 13:31–32), they could act with strong belief.

- "Moving mountains" is a saying that means overcoming obstacles and achieving God's goals (Isaiah 40:4; 49:11; 54:10; 1 Corinthians 13:2).

Matthew 17:22

be delivered: See Matthew 20:18; 26:14–16, 45–49 to see how this prophecy came true.

Matthew 17:24

- Every adult citizen of Israel had to pay the temple tax of one-half shekel. This was a coin weighing 4 grams. In the time of Jesus, priests and some rabbis did not pay this tax.
- Peter spoke on behalf of the twelve apostles (see Matthew 10:2).

Matthew 17:25–26

As an obedient Jew, Jesus would have paid the tax every year, and he did pay it. The lesson Jesus wanted to teach was that as God's Son, he is greater than the temple (Matthew 12:5–6). By this, he showed that a decisive break with the temple was coming (see 16:18–19; 21:33–46).

Matthew 18:1

At that time: Matthew connects the disciples' questions to the earlier teaching about the temple. The disciples started to think their new freedom from Jewish authority gave them their own authority.

Jesus had also spoken about special revelations (Matthew 11:25–27; 13:11–17) and about leadership roles (10:2–4; 19:28). This may have caused jealousy and arguments about power among the disciples. Their disputes may have centered on the importance of Peter (17:25) or the special place of Peter, James, and John (17:1–3).

Matthew 18:1–35

This fourth major teaching in Matthew (see study note on Matthew 5:1–7:29) focuses on how people responded to the Messiah. The disciples accepted him, while the Jewish leaders and most people did not. As this division increased, Jesus taught his disciples about community life.

To follow the standards of Jesus, a community should live with:

- humility (18:1–5),
- sensitivity (18:6–9),
- compassion (18:10–14),
- discipline (18:15–18), and
- forgiveness (18:21–35).

Like the other teachings, a closing statement (19:1–2) connects to the next section.

Matthew 18:3

Like little children means being humble (Matthew 18:4). The disciples had been focused on status and ambition.

Matthew 18:5

Jesus then talked about unity in the community. Welcoming a humble disciple of Jesus is the same as welcoming Jesus himself (see Matthew 10:40–42).

Matthew 18:6

- Cause one ... to stumble: This means to lead believers to turn away from Christ, whether children or adults who have become "like children" in faith (see Matthew 18:3).
- The title little ones emphasizes their humility (see 5:3–12; 18:4; 19:13–15).
- The thought of being drowned with a large millstone around the neck is terrifying. But Jesus warned that causing someone to lose faith will bring even greater suffering (18:7; 26:24; Revelation 18:21; Matthew 22:13).

Matthew 18:8–9

Jesus shifts his concern to the person. You must remove anything that leads you to sin (see Matthew 5:29–30; Colossians 3:5–17).

Matthew 18:10

- Do not look down on any of these: This can happen by refusing to welcome them (Matthew 18:5–6) or by not providing pastoral care when needed (18:12–14; see 19:13–15).
- their angels: See Matthew 4:5–7; Hebrews 1:14.

Matthew 18:12

Just as a shepherd works to find a lost sheep, we must not despise or ignore the "little ones" (Matthew 18:6).

Matthew 18:14

The shepherd's joy is the same as the Father's joy. The goal of pastoral care is to ensure God keeps all his sheep.

Matthew 18:15

If another believer sins, love means we should talk to them privately and point out the wrong (Leviticus

19:17; Luke 17:3; Galatians 6:1; 1 Timothy 5:20; Titus 3:10).

Matthew 18:15–20

Resolving issues should be private at first and only made public if absolutely necessary.

Matthew 18:15–35

The community of believers should stay united and avoid conflicts. Members should seek reconciliation (Matthew 18:15–20) and be ready to forgive (18:21–35). Sometimes, strict discipline might be necessary (18:17).

Matthew 18:16

By requiring one or two others to be present, Jesus stopped slander and false accusations among the congregation (see John 8:17; 2 Corinthians 13:1; 1 Timothy 5:19; Hebrews 10:28).

Matthew 18:17

- The church is the local Christian community.
- An unrepentant person (someone refusing to turn from sin) is to be treated as an outsider, like a lawbreaker. Excluding a person from fellowship (sometimes called excommunication) comes from the belief that God's people must be holy (Acts 5:1–6; Romans 16:17; 1 Corinthians 5:1–13; 2 Corinthians 6:14–18; Galatians 5:7–12; 2 Thessalonians 3:14–15). Sin harms fellowship with both other believers and with God. The goal is not revenge or control, but to restore the sinner to holiness and community (Matthew 18:10–15; Galatians 6:1; James 5:19–20).

Matthew 18:18

Bind ... loose: The privilege and authority Jesus gave to Peter (Matthew 16:19) are here given to the church (or possibly to the twelve apostles, 18:1). The community's decisions, when they are in agreement with God's will, are eternally binding.

Matthew 18:18–20

These sayings guide how to discipline and restore members in the community of disciples.

Matthew 18:19

Anything you ask for: In the context of church discipline (18:15–17), this means discipline must be done in a prayerful way.

Matthew 18:20

Christ is present in the process of church discipline, so this process confirms God's decision.

Matthew 18:21–35

Peter thought forgiving seven times was generous, but Jesus surprised him. A disciple should graciously forgive like God does, without limits and freely (see Matthew 18:10–14). If someone does not forgive in this way, it shows they have not experienced God's forgiveness for themselves (18:35; see 6:12).

Matthew 18:22

Seventy-seven times: sus teaches that forgiveness should have no limit. His followers must forgive sincerely, not only in words but also in attitude and actions (Matthew 18:35; see also Genesis 4:23–24).

Matthew 18:24

Ten thousand talents: The talent was the largest unit of currency, but its value changed over time. This debt was impossible to repay. This amount was more than all of Galilee's tax revenue.

Matthew 18:26

I will pay back everything: the slave's promise to pay the huge debt emphasizes the king's great mercy and the slave's lack of forgiveness (Matthew 18:29–30).

Matthew 18:28

A hundred denarii: The first servant owed a debt about one million times larger than this amount owed to him.

Matthew 18:34

- This is how God reacts to those who refuse to forgive (Matthew 18:35).
- until he should repay all that he owed: This means permanently, because he could never repay the debt.

Matthew 18:35

That is how My heavenly Father will treat each of you: Prison and torture (Matthew 18:34) is a metaphor for hell (see 5:22).

Matthew 19:1–20.34

Jesus was traveling to Jerusalem (Matthew 19:1; 20:29; 21:1). This was another chance to teach the disciples what it means to be his disciples.

Matthew 19:3

There were two different opinions on when a man could divorce his wife:

1. One group of Pharisees, following Rabbi Shammai, believed divorce was only allowable for adultery or serious wrongdoing.
2. The other group, following Rabbi Hillel, thought a man could divorce his wife for any reason, even if she burned his dinner.

Matthew 19:4–5

The Pharisees did not consider all of God's teachings. God intended marriage to be a permanent union (see Genesis 2:18–25; see also 1 Corinthians 7:10–16).

Matthew 19:6

Since God created marriage as a union, people do not have the right to end it. Jesus confirmed that divorce should not happen.

Matthew 19:7–8

Why ... did Moses order: The Pharisees believed Jesus contradicted a command in the law (see Deuteronomy 24:1–4). But Moses allowed divorce only because of people's stubbornness. Jesus introduced the radical idea that what God permits is not always what he desires (see 1 Corinthians 6:12). Divorce is never what God desires (Malachi 2:14–16). It shows the brokenness of human sin.

Matthew 19:9

- Jesus allows only one valid reason for a man to divorce: if his wife has been unfaithful (see Matthew 5:32). For those who thought divorce was easy, Jesus emphasizes God's created order. Marriage is meant to last forever (see Mark 10:11–12).
- commits adultery: This refers to a man who divorces his wife without a valid reason. If he remarries, it is the same as adultery. Jesus aims to reestablish that marriage is permanent.

Matthew 19:11

This statement refers to what the disciples said in Matthew 19:10.

Matthew 19:12

- Eunuchs are men who cannot physically have children, either because of a birth defect or because they were made unable through surgery (castration). Jesus also used the word in a figurative way for those who choose not to marry (see Luke 14:26; 18:29; 1 Corinthians 7:7–8).
- for the sake of the kingdom of Heaven: Jesus was not criticizing marriage. He meant that unmarried people often have more freedom for ministry (see 1 Corinthians 7:25–35).

Matthew 19:13

- Jesus would place his hands on others to bless them (see Luke 4:40; 13:13; see also Genesis 48:14–15; Acts 19:6).
- The disciples tried to stop the parents from bringing children to Jesus. They wanted to protect him, but their action showed the wrong attitude toward children (see Matthew 18:5–6, 10).

Matthew 19:17

- Why do you ask Me: as a Jew, the man should have known that God shows his standard of goodness in his commandments. The man's questions show he did not trust God's revealed will (also Matthew 19:20).
- there is only One who is good: The man might have thought he could be perfectly good on his own, but only God is the truly good. So, God is from where all goodness comes.
- keep the commandments: Jesus might be trying to show the man his own sinfulness by asking him to do the impossible. Or more probably, he is restating that good works are the clear measure of how true a person's faith is (see 7:13–27).

Matthew 19:21–22

When Jesus told the man to go, sell ... come, follow, Jesus revealed that the man had not truly followed the first of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:3). His possessions (his wealth and security) had become his god (see Matthew 6:20, 24; 13:44–46).

Matthew 19:23

- Jesus teaches a lesson about discipleship from the rich man's sad refusal. It is difficult for the rich to humble themselves, admit their needs, and trust in God (see Matthew 5:3; Luke 6:24; 1 Timothy 6:9–10).
- The kingdom of heaven here means eternal life (Matthew 19:16–17, 29) or salvation as a result of God's renewing work (19:25–26).

Matthew 19:24

- Easier for a camel: This analogy emphasizes how difficult it is for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God. Some manuscripts use a Greek word meaning

rope (kamilos) instead of camel (kamēlos), a difference of only one letter.
- to pass through the eye of a needle: This image suggests it is impossible for wealthy people to enter the kingdom of God. But the situation is not completely hopeless (Matthew 19:26–27). See study note on Mark 10:25.

Matthew 19:26

God's renewing grace is completely essential for the wealthy to be able to repent from making wealth an idol, give up their possessions if needed, and follow Jesus (Matthew 19:21).

Matthew 19:28

- You ... will also sit on twelve thrones: The disciples will share in judging. This is a reversal, where those who are rich and powerful now will be judged by those who are humble and poor (see Matthew 19:30).
- Judging can mean both ruling with authority and condemning for wrongdoing (see Revelation 20:4).

Matthew 20:1–16

This parable is like the parable of the lost son (Luke 15:11–32). In both, God shows grace to two groups, but one complains about unfair treatment.

Matthew 20:8

Workers received their pay at the end of the day (Deuteronomy 24:14–15).

Matthew 20:16

See Matthew 5:19 and Matthew 8:11–12.

Matthew 20:20–21

This mother's question seems to have come from her sons, as Jesus answered the sons instead of the mother (compare Mark 10:35–37).

Matthew 20:20–28

Each time Jesus predicted his suffering in the Gospel of Matthew, he also gave teaching about what it means to be his disciple. These teachings showed that discipleship is shaped by Jesus own path of service and sacrifice (see Matthew 16:24–28; 17:24–18:5). This teaching called the Messiah's disciples to imitate his service and sacrifice.

Matthew 20:21

Jesus had already promised positions of authority in God's kingdom to the disciples (Matthew 19:28). The request of the two brothers came from selfish desire to be important, without concern for the suffering the Messiah would soon face (see Matthew 23:6; Luke 14:7–11).

Matthew 20:22

The cup refers to the duty duty, calling, and destiny of Jesus (see Matthew 26:39; John 18:11; also Psalm 75:8; Isaiah 51:17, 22; Revelation 16:19).

Matthew 20:23

You will indeed: James eventually died for his faith (Acts 12:2). John suffered severe persecution (Acts 4:3; 5:40; Revelation 1:9).

Matthew 20:24

The ten ... they were indignant: This shows that selfish ambition was not only in James and John. The other disciples also struggled with it (see also Matthew 21:15; 26:8; Luke 13:14).

Matthew 20:25–28

Rulers who do not know God often desire power and control. But those who follow the Son of Man should not act this way (Matthew 18:1–5; 19:13–15; 23:1–12).

Matthew 20:27

Often the word slave is a metaphor that describes a disciple's submissive relationship to their master (Matthew 8:9; 10:24–25; 24:45–51; 25:14–30). The disciples of Jesus serve others, following his example (for example, John 13:1–17).

Matthew 20:28

- The phrase the Son of Man ... come: This expression suggests that Jesus already existed before his birth on earth. It points back to Daniel's vision of the Son of Man coming from heaven to receive authority and glory (see Daniel 7:13–14).
- as a ransom for many: Jesus said he would freely give his life as a payment to rescue many people. His death brought freedom from the power and penalty of sin (see Matthew 26:26–29; Isaiah 53:10–12; Romans 3:24). In this way, he bought them out of slavery to sin (see Galatians 5:1).

Matthew 20:29–34

The blind men's expression of faith in the Son of David was an acknowledgment of Jesus as the Messiah (see Matthew 21:9; 22:42; 2 Samuel 7:12–16).

Matthew 21:1

Bethphage is a Hebrew name that means house of figs. It was probably on the east side of the Mount of Olives, between Bethany and Jerusalem.

Matthew 21:1–28.20

Jesus entering Jerusalem starts Matthew's story of how the Messiah's suffering and resurrection establish salvation.

Matthew 21:3

Jesus was revealing himself as the Lord who, as king of Israel, goes up to Mount Zion on a donkey (Matthew 21:5; see Zechariah 9:9).

Matthew 21:4–5

This part of the Old Testament fulfillment emphasizes the Messiah's peaceful, humble, and saving work (see Matthew 11:28–30; Isaiah 62:11; Zechariah 9:9–10).

Matthew 21:11

- The crowds with Jesus saw him as a prophet, empowered by God to teach and perform miracles.
- The mention from Nazareth in Galilee emphasizes the humble beginnings of Jesus (see Matthew 2:23).

Matthew 21:12

- Buying and selling happened in the temple complex, in the Court of the Gentiles.
- Money changers made profit by exchanging foreign money into the official Jewish currency. Jesus criticized this commercial activity because it dishonored the holiness of the temple (see Mark 11:11–18).

Matthew 21:12–13

The close association of the temple cleansing (see John 2:13–16) and the cursing of the fig tree (Matthew 21:18–19) shows Jesus as the Messiah (God's chosen one). He confronted Israel and warned that God judges those who reject the Messiah and his message.

Matthew 21:13

What Jesus did was right because people were using money in a way that desecrated God's glory.

Matthew 21:15

The Jewish leaders' refusal to believe is contrasted with the joyful faith and praise of little children (see Matthew 18:1–14; 19:13–15).

Matthew 21:16

Have you never read: Jesus asked this challenging question to opponents who failed to see that his ministry fulfilled the promises about the Messiah (see also Matthew 12:3, 5; 19:4; 21:42; 22:31).

Matthew 21:19

- Nothing on it except leaves: Mark notes that "it was not the season for figs" (see Mark 11:13). It was spring, just before Passover. Figs start growing in spring but ripen in fall.
- immediately the tree withered: Matthew seems to have shortened the story (compare Matthew 21:18–22; Mark 11:13–14, 20–23). The cursing of the fig tree symbolizes God's judgment on Israel for rejecting the Messiah (see Matt 3:9; 8:11–12). The Israelites are like a fig tree that looks promising but has no fruit. This was especially true of the hypocritical leaders. They did not bear fruit, symbolic of receiving the Messiah (see 21:33–46).

Matthew 21:22

Jesus was encouraging the disciples to trust in God and pray with faith. He was not promising that God would approve everything they might desire (1 John 5:14–15).

Matthew 21:23

Elders of the people: This refers to the family leaders from each tribe. They were part of the Sanhedrin, the Jewish council in Jerusalem (compare Ezra 5:5; 6:14; 10:8).

Matthew 21:23–22.46

This section focuses on how Jewish leaders challenged the authority of Jesus. Each time, the wisdom of Jesus revealed their lack of spiritual understanding. These debates also revealed the status of Jesus as the Messiah and the consequences of rejecting him. Sadly, the leaders became more resistant with each encounter and plotted to kill Jesus (Matthew 21:23, 46; 22:15–17, 23, 34, 41).

Matthew 21:24

Jesus gave a riddle. The answer solved the leaders' question and placed them in a dilemma that showed what was in their hearts (Matthew 21:25–26). Asking a counter-question was common in debates at that time.

Matthew 21:25

The minsitry of John, like the ministry of Jesus, was controversial (see Matthew 3:1, 5–6). This was true especially after John publicly criticized Herod Antipas for his sins (see 14:4). The Jewish leaders did not want to admit that John's work was from God. They had refused to believe John and repent of their sins (3:2). They also refused to accept Jesus as the Messiah (John 1:29–34).

Matthew 21:27

The Jewish leaders did not have the honesty or bravery to admit their beliefs about John. So, it was fair for Jesus not to answer their question.

Matthew 21:28–32

This parable continues to emphasize why John is important.

Matthew 21:28–22.14

Three parables expose the guilt of those who rejected the Messiah and lost their special status as God's chosen people. God now considers only those who accept Jesus as the Messiah as his people.

Matthew 21:29

I will not: This response must have offended Jews who learned from a young age to show respect for the authority of a father (see Matthew 8:21–22).

Matthew 21:32

The right way to live is to follow the will of God (Matthew 3:15; 5:20; see also Proverbs 8:20; 12:28).

Matthew 21:33–46

In this story, Jesus refers back to Isaiah 5:1–7. The people of Israel who rejected God's Messiah lost the privilege of being God's people. Now, God has called the Christian community, made up of both Jews and Gentiles (non-Jews), to be his people (see Romans 9:4–8; 11:1–12).

Matthew 21:34–35

He sent his servants: The prophets had spoken God's message to Israel. In this parable, the tenant farmers represent Israel's leaders, whom Jesus blamed for killing God's prophets (Matthew 23:29–37).

Matthew 21:37

Finally: God's revelation reached its goal in Jesus (see Matthew 13:16–17; Hebrews 1:1–2).

Matthew 21:40

when the owner of the vineyard returns: The vineyard owner's return symbolizes the Lord's coming for judgment (see Matthew 16:27; 24:1–36).

Matthew 21:41

The Jewish religious leaders declared their own condemnation.

Matthew 21:42

The cornerstone was either the first stone of the foundation or the last stone placed, like the top of an arch. The builders rejected this stone as unworthy, but it was actually the most important. Jesus was talking about his role in the kingdom of God (Matthew 21:43) and how the Jewish religious leaders rejected him.

Matthew 21:43

- Taken away from you: Either the privilege of being God's chosen nation no longer belonged to the Jews, or the religious leaders had lost the privilege of being leaders of God's people (see Romans 9–11).
- The Christian community is a nation that will produce the proper "fruit" or right results. This means a life of trust and obedience that shows the start of God's kingdom (see Matthew 3:8; 7:15–20; 12:33; 13:8, 26).

Matthew 21:44

Those who opposed the Messiah would soon win a temporary victory. But the Messiah would eventually defeat them. The stone would crush them because the death of Jesus on the cross led to his vindication and triumph (see also Daniel 2:34–35, 44–45).

Matthew 21:45

This explanation fits with Matthew's theme of God's judgment on the Jewish leaders who misled the people of Israel (see Matthew 23:13–15).

Matthew 22:1–14

In this parable, Israel had often rejected God's message in the past. In the same way, Israel rejected the Messiah and faced judgment. In Israel's place, God raised up the church (Matthew 16:17–19; 21:43). God also expects the church to live in righteousness (Romans 11:11–24).

Matthew 22:2

- The king represents God, and his son is Jesus (Galatians 4:4; Hebrews 1:1–2).

- The feast represents the kingdom of the Messiah.

Matthew 22:3–5

those he had invited: This refers to the nation of Israel. They ignored God's servants, the prophets (see study note on Matthew 21:33–46).

Matthew 22:7

Jesus was referring to the future destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 (see Matthew 23:37–39; 24:2).

Matthew 22:8

People who refuse God's invitation do not deserve to enter his kingdom (see Matthew 3:8; 10:13, 37–38).

Matthew 22:9

as many as you can find: God's invitation is now open to all people, not only the nation of Israel (see Matthew 28:16–20; compare 10:5–6; 15:21–28).

Matthew 22:10

both evil and good: See Matthew 13:24–50.

Matthew 22:11

Wearing the right clothes symbolizes spiritual qualities that show true faith (see Matthew 7:13–27).

Matthew 22:13

- weeping and gnashing of teeth: This phrase describes the intense pain and sorrow that come from being condemned for sin and unbelief (see Matthew 8:12; 13:42, 50; 24:51; 25:30).
- outer darkness: This is a picture of eternal punishment, shown as being far from God's presence.

Matthew 22:14

Many people receive an invitation to the kingdom. But God only choses a few who faithfully obey Jesus.

Matthew 22:15–22

In first-century Palestine, debates about Roman taxes were intense (see also Matthew 17:24–27).

Matthew 22:16

The Pharisees were strict Jewish leaders who opposed Roman rule. They strongly resisted Roman control and wanted to protect Jewish traditions and independence. They usually disagreed with the supporters of Herod. But in this case, they joined together because both groups hated Jesus.

Matthew 22:17

Is it lawful ... or not?: They asked the question to try and trap Jesus. If he said no, they could arrest him for rebelling against Rome. If he said yes, they could accuse him of supporting Roman oppression.

Matthew 22:18

You hypocrites: See study note on Matthew 23:13.

Matthew 22:20

The people had to pay the poll tax with the denarius coin. This coin showed the picture and title of Caesar (the Roman emperor). Old Testament rules against worshiping images (Exodus 20:4; Leviticus 26:1; Deuteronomy 4:15–24) made this coin controversial for Jews (see Josephus, War 2.9.2–3). To avoid conflict, some Roman governors in Palestine minted coins without human images. This showed respect for Jewish religious concerns.

Matthew 22:21

Jesus answered with wisdom. He said people should give Caesar the honor that belongs to him, but they must give God the greater honor and loyalty. Being loyal to God does not always mean being disloyal to human rulers. Jesus showed that there are two realms of authority, Caesar's and God's, and God's authority is greater (Acts 4:19).

Matthew 22:23

The Sadducees (see Matthew 3:7) described a situation about levirate marriage. This was a Jewish custom where a man marries his brother's widow (see Genesis 38:6–11; Deuteronomy 25:5–6). They tried to use this as proof that resurrection from the dead is impossible.

Matthew 22:23–33

The resurrection was an important topic in the time of Jesus. But the people only asked about it to try and trap him.

Matthew 22:29

the power of God: This probably means God's ability to resurrect people who have died.

Matthew 22:30

like the angels in heaven: Jesus was not teaching that people will be without gender in heaven. Nor was he criticizing God's order of marriage and sexuality. Instead, he was confirming that God will transform people into a glorious new existence (see 1 Corinthians

15:35–49; 2 Corinthians 5:1–5). In this new existence, parts of the current world, like marriage, will not be present.

Matthew 22:31–32

God spoke of himself as the God of Abraham in the present tense. This shows that Abraham is still alive and that there will be a resurrection.

Matthew 22:36

Many strict Jews believed that every commandment was equally important. Because of this, a careless answer to the question could lead to an accusation of rejecting God's law.

Matthew 22:37

Jesus answers using the Shema (Deuteronomy 6:4–9), a key statement of God's covenant with Israel. The first Hebrew word in Deuteronomy 6:4–9 is shema', meaning "hear!"

Matthew 22:39

Love your neighbor as yourself: Leviticus 19:18; see also Romans 13:9; Galatians 5:6, 14; James 2:8.

Matthew 22:40

hang on: The words of Jesus showed that God's will is unified and consistent, as it is recorded in Scripture.

Matthew 22:41–46

After Jesus defended himself against the traps of his opponents (21:23–22:40), he asked them a question. How can the Messiah be called both the son of David and also the Lord of David (Psalm 110:1).

Matthew 22:42

Whose son is He? ... David's: See study note on Matthew 9:27; also see 2 Samuel 7:12–14; Psalms 2:7–9; 110; Isaiah 11:1, 10; Jeremiah 23:5–6.

Matthew 22:44

The quote is from Psalm 110:1 and New Testament writers often use it to describe Jesus (see Acts 2:34–35; 1 Corinthians 15:25; Hebrews 1:13; 2:8; 10:12–13; Revelation 3:21).

Matthew 22:45

how can He be David's son?: The answer is that Jesus is not only the son of David; he is also the Son of God (Matthew 14:33).

Matthew 22:46

No one could answer him because they had never thought the Messiah would be God as a human being in the flesh (see John 1:1–14).

Matthew 23:1

The Jewish religious leaders tried to find a reason to accuse Jesus publicly but could not (Matthew 21:23–22:46). Jesus then addressed the crowds and his disciples to openly criticize the religious leaders for often failing to obey God's righteous standards.

Matthew 23:1–25.46

This last extended teaching (see study note on Matthew 5:1–7:29) focuses on the judgment awaiting those who reject the Messiah.

Matthew 23:2

The scribes and Pharisees sit in Moses' seat: This means that they give authoritative explanations about the law of Moses. They passed down oral traditions associated with the law and thought to be from Moses. They judged religious and social issues based on these traditions (see Matthew 15:2).

Matthew 23:3

practice and obey: This was not a full confirmation of everything the Pharisees taught (see Matthew 15:1–20; 16:5–12; 23:13–39). It might refer only to teachings that agreed with the law of Moses, or it could be bitter irony or sarcasm. Jesus might also have advised conforming to the Pharisees' teachings to avoid causing offense (17:24–27).

Matthew 23:4

- heavy, burdensome loads: According to the rabbis, there were 613 laws with commands and prohibitions (see 11:28–30; Acts 15:10, 28).
- not willing to lift a finger: The religious leaders were not willing to ease or change these traditional laws.

Matthew 23:5

- phylacteries: Pious Jews sometimes wore small prayer boxes, called phylacteries. These were placed on the head and the upper left arm. Inside were written copies of important Old Testament commands (see Deuteronomy 6:6–9; 11:18–19).
- Another custom was wearing tassels, which were also a sign of devotion (see Matthew 9:20; see also Numbers 15:38–41). Some made their tassels extra long to draw attention to their religious devotion.

Matthew 23:6

the chief seats in the synagogue: These were close to the Torah scrolls and faced the congregation.

Matthew 23:7

Rabbi was a title given to an authoritative and respected Jewish teacher.

Matthew 23:8

Rabbi: In Judaism, these men were authoritative mediators for sharing knowledge about God (see Matthew 23:7). But under the new covenant, there is only one authoritative teacher, Jesus himself as the Messiah (see Jeremiah 31:31–34).

Matthew 23:8–12

Jesus does not forbid using titles (especially for one's father). Instead, he warns against claiming undue honor when teaching about God. In the community of Jesus, everyone is equal and knows God (see 12:46–50; 18:15–20). The titles Rabbi, Father, and Teacher are similar in meaning.

Matthew 23:9

- Later Jewish writings show that people respected teachers by calling them Father (see, for example, Mishnah Eduyyoth 1:4).
- one Father: See Matthew 6:9; Malachi 2:10; compare 1 Corinthians 4:15.

Matthew 23:10

Instructor: This title means the role and office of guiding others to understand God. Jesus, not the scribes and Pharisees, is the teacher of God's will (Matthew 5:17).

Matthew 23:11–12

The disciples of Jesus should lead by serving others, in distinct contrast to Israel's religious leaders (described in 23:5–7).

Matthew 23:13

- Woe to you: This is a distinct warning about God's judgment.
- hypocrites!: In English, hypocrisy means a contradiction between what is real and what seems to be real. In the Bible, it means misunderstanding God's will, misleading others, and facing God's judgment. This often includes: desire for fame and power (Matthew 23:5–12), misuse of teaching authority, false teachings (23:13–22), and focusing on minor ethical details (23:23–28).

A suitable English word for these behaviors is heresy. The Pharisees and religious teachers showed these traits. As the Christian church grew, these traits continued to appear (for example, 1 Timothy 4:1–3; 2 Peter 2:1–22). So God's children must always be on guard against them (James 4:7–10; 1 Peter 2:1–3).

- you shut the kingdom: This comes through their false teachings and opposition to Jesus (see Matthew 9:32–34; 12:22–37; 15:12–14; 21:15; John 9:13–34). The Jewish religious teachers and Pharisees stopped others from hearing and believing the truth about the Messiah.

Matthew 23:13–36

Matthew gathered seven warnings of sorrow to come (literally woe to you) inspired by similar Old Testament lists (Isaiah 5:8–23; Habakkuk 2:6–20). Matthew arranged them to reach a climax with the killing of the prophets.

Matthew 23:15

- A convert (proselyte) fully accepted Judaism by performing ceremonies like baptism, sacrifice, and circumcision (see Acts 13:43).

A convert differed from a "God-fearer." A God-fearer was a person who accepted some Jewish beliefs, especially monotheism (belief in one God), without fully converting to Judaism (see Luke 7:4–5; Acts 10:2). To win a single convert likely means persuading God-fearers to fully convert by becoming circumcised (compare Galatians 2:3, 14; 5:2–12; 6:12–13).

- of hell: The Greek word here is Gehenna. It was a valley outside Jerusalem used as a place of burning; See study note on Matthew 5:29.

Matthew 23:16–22

The religious leaders said that some oaths were less binding, and this allowed them to deceive people. But Jesus called for honesty and for keeping every commitment (see Matthew 5:33–37).

Matthew 23:23

The Jewish teachers of religious law and Pharisees believed that careful and precise tithing showed their dedication to the law. Without denying the importance of tithing, Jesus revealed that they completely ignored the more important parts of the law (Isaiah 1:16–17; Jeremiah 22:3; Hosea 6:6; Micah 6:8; Zechariah 7:9).

Matthew 23:24

gnat ... camel: In Aramaic, the language Jesus likely spoke, these two words sound similar (qalma ... gamla). This makes a wordplay or pun. Jesus used the contrast between a tiny gnat and a huge camel to show the hypocrisy of focusing on small details while ignoring much greater issues.

Matthew 23:26

If a person is pure inside, it leads to doing the right things. But doing the right things does not make a person pure inside (Matthew 6:19–34; 12:33–37; 15:15–20).

Matthew 23:27–28

Jewish people used to coat limestone tombs, like funerary urns or ossuaries, with a mixture of marble and lime. This filled the holes and made the tombs look nicer. It also helped visitors to Jerusalem see and avoid them, preventing contamination. Jesus did not criticize decorating tombs. Instead, he compared these whitewashed tombs to Jewish religious teachers and Pharisees. Both looked good on the outside but had contamination and impurity on the inside.

Matthew 23:29

By building and decorating the tombs for the prophets, the teachers of religious law and Pharisees showed outward support for the prophets. But inwardly they were of the same sinful character as their ancestors who had murdered the prophets.

Matthew 23:32

Fill up, then, the measure of the sin of your fathers: By killing God's Messiah, they would complete Israel's history of killing God's prophets (see 1 Thessalonians 2:14–16).

Matthew 23:35

This covers the first and last murders recorded in the Hebrew Bible. Abel was killed in Genesis 4:8–11, and Zechariah in 2 Chronicles 24:15–22, which is the last book in the Hebrew Bible order. Jesus implies that his generation would be held guilty for all the murders of God's righteous servants in the Old Testament (compare Matt 27:25).

Matthew 23:37

- Even though Jesus had just given a severe judgment against Israel (Matthew 23:29–36), he truly wanted them to repent and accept God's grace.
- as a hen: This is an image of protective care (see also Deuteronomy 32:11; Ruth 2:12; Psalms 17:8; 36:7; 57:1; 61:4; 91:4).

Matthew 23:38

your house is left to you desolate: God would leave the temple (Ezekiel 10:18–19; 11:22–23; compare Matthew 1:23). Then God would allow the destruction of both the temple and Jerusalem.

Matthew 23:39

Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord: his may point to a future time when the nation of Israel will turn to the Messiah (see also Romans 11:12–32).

Matthew 24:1

The architecture of the temple was a source of pride for the Jewish people (see study note on Mark 13:1).

Matthew 24:1–31

Some think chapter 24 is about the return of Jesus at the end of time. Others think it as a prediction of events in AD 70, when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. Some think it refers to both events. See also study notes on Mark 13.

Matthew 24:2

not one stone: The destruction of Jerusalem and the temple showed God's judgment against Israel (see 1 Kings 9:7–9; Jeremiah 7:8–15; 9:10–12; 26:6, 18; Micah 3:12; see also Isaiah 64:11; Luke 19:44; Acts 6:14).

Matthew 24:3

- The Greek word parousia means coming or appearing.
- end of the age (or end of the world): This phrase refers to the final end of a period in salvation history (see Matthew 13:39–40, 49; also Hebrews 9:26). The second coming of Jesus will end normal history with a final judgment. The disciples believed the temple's destruction and the end of history had a close link.

Matthew 24:4–8

Jesus warned his disciples not to be tricked by false messiahs and not to lose hope when disasters come. These things do not mean the end has come right away. History must follow the course God has set. The signs in Matthew 24:4–8 are not the end themselves but events that come before the end.

Matthew 24:5

claiming, 'I am the Christ,': During AD 30 to 70, many false prophets and miracle workers claimed to be the Messiah. They convinced people to follow them, promising salvation (Josephus, Antiquities 18.4.1; 20.5.1; 20.8.6; War 6.5.2). The first known person to openly claim to be the Messiah was Bar Kochba in AD 132. It is unclear if Jesus was talking about impostors before the temple's destruction, false messiahs throughout the church Age, or possibly during a future difficult time.

Matthew 24:6

- These things must happen: This shows that times of trouble are part of God's plan as he moves history toward its conclusion (see Matthew 24:7, 29–30; 2 Thessalonians 2:8–12).
- the end: This might mean the end of a period (like in AD 70) or the end of human history as we know it (compare Matthew 24:13–14; see also 10:22; 13:39–40, 49).

Matthew 24:8

beginning of birth pains: God's people should expect intense suffering right before the second coming of Jesus (see also Mathhew 24:29–31; Isaiah 13:8; 26:17; Jeremiah 4:31; 6:24; Micah 4:9–10).

Matthew 24:9

hated (see Acts 28:22): At the end of the first century, the Roman historian Tacitus described Christians as "the hated ones of mankind" (Tacitus, Annals 15.44). The suffering of righteous people sometimes has the purpose of encouraging repentance and obedience (see Exodus 4:31; Deuteronomy 4:30; Judges 10:6–16; Psalms 34:19; 37:39; 50:15).

Matthew 24:10

Some people will stop being loyal to Jesus because of persecution (Matthew 10:25; 13:21; 16:24–28; 26:33).

Matthew 24:12

the love of most will grow cold (see Revelation 2:4): If the love within the community of the disciples of Jesus disappears, the community stops being what God designed it to be.

Matthew 24:13

the one who perseveres stays loyal to Jesus, even when persecuted. The end could mean the end of their life, the judgment on Israel in AD 70, or the end of history.

Matthew 24:14

- in all the world: This points to the future mission to the Gentiles (see Matthew 21:43; 28:16–20). Before the end comes, there will be a time, whether short or long, when the good news spreads among the nations.
- Jesus said the end will be marked by three signs. First is "the abomination of desolation" (24:15). Second is severe persecution (24:16–28). Finally comes the sign of the Son of Man (24:29–31).

Matthew 24:15

- described by the prophet Daniel: He spoke about the desecration (or desolation) of the temple (see Daniel 8:13; 9:27; 11:31; 12:11). It would be made unclean and ruined.
- the abomination of desolation could be:

1. A false priest taking over the priesthood (see Josephus, War 4.3.6–10).
2. Unlawful images of God or humans, or certain people who cannot be in the temple. These people would include Antiochus Epiphanes, Caligula, Vespasian, or Titus (see Josephus, War 4.4.1–4.7.1).
3. The antichrist being present in the temple (compare 1 Maccabees 1:54–64; 2 Maccabees 8:17). The term "antichrist" refers to a person or teaching that opposes Jesus Christ and his work.

- let the reader understand: This hidden message shows a special connection between the writer and reader, based on a shared belief that these events fulfill the prophecies of Daniel 9, 11, and 12.

Matthew 24:20

- The Jewish historian Josephus records that the Jordan River swells in winter, making it harder to cross (see War 4.7.5). Muddy roads also made travel difficult in winter.
- Jews usually did not travel on the Sabbath, so that they could rest as God commanded (see Genesis 2:1–3; Exodus 20:8–11; 23:12; 31:12–17; Leviticus 23:3; Deuteronomy 5:12–15; Jeremiah 17:19–27).

Matthew 24:21

great tribulation, unmatched: Similar language appears in Nehemiah 9:37; Jeremiah 11:16; Daniel 12:1; Joel 2:1–17. The Jewish historian Josephus documented the extreme violence of the times (see War 5.10.2–3).

Matthew 24:22

God's chosen people persevere (Matthew 24:13) and remain faithful (24:37–25:46; see Isaiah 65:8–9; Romans 11:7).

Matthew 24:24

- false Christs and false prophets (see Matthew 7:15; 24:4–8; also Acts 13:6; 2 Peter 2:1; 1 John 2:18; 4:1): Revelation describes a particular false prophet (see Revelation 16:13).
- signs and wonders: Not all miracles are proof of God's approval (see Deuteronomy 13:1–4; Revelation 13:13).

Matthew 24:26

- Some Jewish prophets persuaded people to follow them into the desert to witness signs of salvation (see Matthew 24:4–8).
- in the inner rooms: This might refer to secretive groups, like those at Qumran, or small fellowship groups linked to the Pharisees.

Matthew 24:26–28

These verses expand on Matthew 24:23. Jews debated where and how the Messiah would appear. The Messiah's glorious arrival and vindication will be clear to everyone.

Matthew 24:27–28

Lightning here may point to the great cosmic signs that will mark the coming of the Messiah (see Matthew 24:29–31; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18). The focus is on how easy the lightning is to see, not how suddenly it comes. Jesus probably shared these teachings to prevent early excitement about the end of time (1 Thessalonians 4:13–5:10; 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12).

Matthew 24:29

'The sun will be darkened ... the heavens will be shaken.': This could be literal, as is fitting for a dramatic revelation of God's Son. Or, it could be a metaphor for a major cosmic event (see Acts 2:17–21; Hebrews 12:26–27; 2 Peter 3:10; Revelation 6:12–13). The Old Testament often uses similar apocalyptic language to describe political disasters and the collapse of governments as cosmic judgments from God (for example, Isaiah 13:9–16; Ezekiel 32:1–10; Joel 2:1–17; Amos 8:7–10).

Matthew 24:29–31

These sayings indicate the most important part of the discussion and answer the second question the disciples asked (see Matthew 24:3). Some believe 24:29–31 describes God's judgment on the Jewish people in AD 70. In this view, the apocalyptic images and metaphors picture the destruction of Jerusalem.

Others see these verses as pointing to the second coming of Christ at the end of history.

Matthew 24:30

- the sign of the Son of Man: The sign is probably the Son of Man himself (see Matthew 12:38–42; 16:4). His coming shows that God has vindicated him (proved him right; see 26:64). It will also cause deep mourning for those who face God's judgment.
- all the tribes of the earth: This could also mean "all the tribes of the land." The Greek term used here (phulai) often refers to the tribes of Israel. It is not the usual term for Gentiles (ethnoi). This suggests that it may refer to a national disaster in Israel (see Matthew 21:43; Zechariah 12:10–14).
- the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven: See Daniel 7:13. Many think this means the Son of Man will descend from God's presence to live on earth as judge and savior. This is the second coming of Christ. Others believe it describes the Son of Man coming in judgment, but not necessarily as the second coming of Christ (see Matthew 10:23; 16:27; 19:28; 25:31; 26:64; 28:18).

Matthew 24:31

Some believe this passage predicts the rapture, when God's people are gathered by angels (Matthew 13:41; 16:27; 25:31). Others think the word angeloi (Greek for "messengers") here refers to human messengers (11:10; Luke 7:24; 9:52; James 2:25). In this view, Jesus is describing the spread of the good news among the Gentiles (see Matthew 21:33–46; 22:1–14; Deuteronomy 30:1–10; Isaiah 27:13; Zechariah 2:6–13).

Matthew 24:33

- all these things: This refers to events connected to the destruction of the temple. This phrase is first used in Matthew 23:36 (see 24:2, 8).
- He is near (or it is near): It could mean the return of Jesus (see James 5:9; Revelation 3:20), the destruction of the temple, or the end of history (see Luke 21:31).

Matthew 24:34

this generation: In Matthew, generation refers particularly to the current Jews who do not trust in Jesus. This focuses especially on the leaders who have tried

to make the people reject the Messiah (Matthew 11:16; 12:39, 41–42, 45; 16:4; 23:36).

Matthew 24:35

The words of Jesus are as reliable as the words of God (see Matthew 5:18; Isaiah 40:8; 55:11; 59:21).

Matthew 24:36

- That day is the day of judgment.
- nor the Son: This phrase shows that Jesus did not know the exact time. Acts 1:7 suggests the same idea. Because no one knows the day, Jesus told his followers to stay watchful and faithful (see Matthew 24:37–25:46). This statement should discourage anyone from trying to calculate the exact date when our Lord will return.

Matthew 24:37

- at the coming of the Son of Man: This refers to the second coming of Jesus (see Matthew 24:3; compare Luke 17:26).
- in the days of Noah (see Genesis 6:9–22; 2 Peter 2:5; 3:5–6): This is not comparing how serious the sins were. Instead, it shows that people did not notice what God was doing. They were too focused on everyday pleasures and celebrations (Matthew 6:19–34).

Matthew 24:37–41

The second coming of Jesus will surprise people, just like the flood of Noah did (Genesis 7). The only way to be ready is to live consistently alert and obedient (compare Luke 17:26–27, 34–35).

Matthew 24:37–25.46

Jesus now applied his prophecies (Matthew 24:1–36) to his disciples so they would stay faithful and be ready for his second coming.

Matthew 24:40–41

The word taken most likely means taken in judgment, either in AD 70 or at the end of history. Left would then mean remaining to enter a new time. This new time could be the age of the church (see 21:43; 22:1–14) or the thousand-year reign of Christ on earth (the Millennium).

Matthew 24:42

keep watch: This means to actively and energetically obey the Lord with a single focus (see Matthew 25:13; 26:38–41).

Matthew 24:45

servant: Those who were listening to Jesus might have thought of God's special servants, the prophets and lawgivers. But Jesus often used servant as a metaphor, so it is likely he was describing every disciple's responsibility (see Matthew 10:24–25; 13:27–28; 18:23–35; 20:26).

Matthew 24:45–51

This parable and the next three dramatize the importance of faithfully obeying while waiting for Jesus to return (Matthew 25:1–13, 14–30, 31–46).

Matthew 25:1

- to meet the bridegroom: This image points to the coming of the Messiah (see Mark 2:19–20).
- We do not know the exact wedding customs of that time. Some believe the bridesmaids led the bride to the bridegroom's home. He stayed away until the wedding feast began. The bridesmaids would wait for his arrival and then escort him to the feast (Matthew 25:10).

Others think the bridegroom might have arrived late at night at the bride's home, where they announced him. After celebrating with the bride's guests, the groom would take his bride to his home under torches or lamps.

Matthew 25:1–13

This parable confirms the need to be alert and ready for Christ's return (Matthew 25:13; see also Luke 12:35–36).

Matthew 25:3

Some people think the oil represents something specific (such as the Holy Spirit). But it more likely emphasizes the need to prepare for Christ's second coming.

Matthew 25:5

Both the prudent and the foolish bridesmaids sleep while waiting. The parable criticizes only the foolish bridesmaids' failure to bring enough oil.

Matthew 25:6

The bridegroom arriving at midnight while the bridesmaids slept makes a further point: the second coming of Jesus will be sudden and unexpected (Matthew 14:42–51).

Matthew 25:14–30

This parable teaches that the Lord expects his servants to be faithful to the task given to them while waiting for his return. The delay of Christ's return will cause some to do evil things (Matthew 24:48–49), some to become inactive (25:3), and others may become fearfully passive (25:18).

Matthew 25:19

After a long time: This emphasizes the long wait for Christ's return (Matthew 24:45–51).

Matthew 25:21

- See Matthew 24:45–51; Luke 16:10.
- Enter into the joy of your master!: This shows the Father's approval. It may also point to the Messiah's great banquet (see Matthew 6:1, 4, 6, 18; 9:9–17).

Matthew 25:24

I knew that you are a hard man: This servant uses a false understanding of his master as an excuse for being lazy.

Matthew 25:29

God gives plenty of grace to those who are faithful with what they already have (see Matthew 13:12).

Matthew 25:31

sit on His glorious throne: This represents a position of judgment (see Matthew 19:28; 22:44; Daniel 7:13–14).

Matthew 25:31–46

This describes the final judgment of which Jesus had been warning (see Matthew 7:13–27; 8:10–12; 11:20–24; 12:38–42; 13:24–30, 36–43; 16:24–28; 24:37–25:30).

Matthew 25:33

His right hand: This is a place of honor (Genesis 48:13–20; Psalm 110:1).

Matthew 25:34

prepared for you from the foundation of the world: This phrase might be a reference to God choosing people for salvation before time began (see Matthew 13:10–17; Ephesians 1:4; Revelation 17:8). Or it might only refer to the God's kingdom as a place (compare Matthew 25:41).

Matthew 25:35–36

The actions mentioned here are often called "deeds of mercy." These were acts of kindness toward those in need (see Isaiah 58:1–12; Ezekiel 18:7; James 1:26–27). These good deeds are not efforts to earn God's approval. Instead, they come from a love for Christ that results in compassion toward others (see Matthew 6:1–4).

Matthew 25:37

These righteous people (see Mathhew 5:6, 20) obey God's will as Jesus taught them. They show this most clearly through acts of love (7:12; 9:9–13; 22:34–40; 25:35–40).

Matthew 25:40

these brothers of Mine: This phrase may show the close bond Jesus had with his disciples (see 10:42; 18:1–14; Galatians 6:10). Or it could refer to all humanity, regardless of their faith (see Matthew 6:1–4; 25:43; Proverbs 19:17). The phrase brothers of Mine suggests the first meaning (Matthew 12:46–50; 18:15–35; 23:8; 28:10). But it does not exclude the duty to care for others in general (see Luke 10:30–37).

Matthew 25:46

The Greek word for eternal can mean "lasting forever" or "lasting for an age." It refers to "the age to come" (Matthew 13:39–40, 49; 24:3; John 17:3; 2 Thessalonians 1:9; Philemon 1:15; 1 John 5:11, 13).

Some hope that the punishment of the damned will end after "an age." God will either destroy or forgive them. Yet, the comparison between eternal life and eternal punishment strongly suggests it means "lasting forever." This is because eternal life does not end (see also Luke 16:19–31; Hebrews 6:2; Revelation 20:10).

Matthew 26:2

The irony is that the Son of Man, who will one day judge the nations (Matthew 25:31–46), must first be unfairly judged and condemned to death by evil people. The death of Jesus was the ultimate Passover sacrifice (see John 19:31–37; 1 Corinthians 5:7).

Matthew 26:3

- Caiaphas was the high priest. He lived near the temple in Jerusalem's upper city. This meeting was not at the usual place or time, so it was urgent and probably secret. The Sanhedrin (the official Jewish council) usually met in the council chamber. The council chamber was located either at the southern end of the court of the Israelites in the temple or on the western edge of the temple hill.
- Joseph Caiaphas was the son-in-law of Annas (see John 18:13). He served as high priest from AD 18

to 36 (John 11:49). He had the longest term of any high priest from Herod's rule until AD 70. They had removed Annas, his father-in-law, from his position but he was still called high priest as well (see Luke 3:2; John 18:13, 19–24).

Matthew 26:5

At Passover, Jerusalem was crowded with pilgrims. The Jewish leaders feared losing their authority if they caused or permitted anything that looked like a revolt against Rome (see Matthew 21:8–11, 14–16).

Matthew 26:6

Simon was a man who had once suffered from leprosy. Jesus being in his home showed the forgiving and healing love that Jesus often gave to people who were outcasts (see 8:7; 9:10).

Matthew 26:6–13

A similar anointing happened earlier in Galilee (Luke 7:36–50). Matthew includes this event here (compare John 12:1–8) to highlight different responses to Jesus. While the Jewish leaders were plotting to kill Jesus (Matthew 26:3–5) and Judas was preparing to betray him (26:14–16), the woman honored Jesus with her actions.

Matthew 26:7

The jar of costly perfume was used for burial customs (see Mark 16:1; Luke 23:56–24:1; John 12:1–7; 19:38–42). It was made from nard, a plant harvested in India. The perfume was worth almost a full year's wages(John 12:5).

Matthew 26:8

they were indignant: John 12:4 shows that Judas Iscariot caused this reaction.

Matthew 26:12

prepared My body for burial: We do not know if the woman fully understood what she was doing. The anointing also symbolizes Jesus as king and priest (1 Samuel 10:1; 2 Kings 9:6; Exodus 29:7).

Matthew 26:14–16

Judas sold himself to the authorities (see also John 11:57), kept it secret (Matthew 26:25), and led them to Jesus at the right time to arrest him (26:47–56; see John 18:2). Later, feeling guilty, Judas killed himself (Matthew 27:3–10; see Acts 1:15–22).

Judas was known for his greed (Matthew 26:14–15; John 12:4–6; 13:29). Some think he may also have been disappointed in the kind of Messiah Jesus was, ashamed after the anointing of Jesus (see John 12:1–8). Others think he may have been resentful of the leadership of Peter, James, and John. Whatever his reasons, Judas's betrayal was still part of God's larger plan (Acts 1:16–17).

Matthew 26:18

My time: The Messiah would now complete the work for which he was commissioned, to die for the sins of the world.

Matthew 26:23

dipped his hand into the bowl with Me: Everyone would dip their food into a shared bowl, which probably had herbs and fruit puree in it. Sharing a meal showed friendship and trust, so having a betrayer there was shocking (Matthew 26:21; but see John 13:26).

Matthew 26:24

as it is written: Jesus might have been referring to Isaiah 53:7–9 or the broader Old Testament theme of a suffering Messiah. This verse shows both God's sovereign will and human responsibility.

Matthew 26:25

- Judas referred to Jesus as Rabbi, but the other disciples call him "Lord" (Mathhew 26:22).
- You have said it yourself: This mysterious statement confirmed that Judas was the betrayer.

Matthew 26:26

- Deuteronomy 16:3 calls the unleavened bread of the Passover (see Exodus 12:18) the "bread of affliction." This is because it symbolizes the hardships in Egypt.
- During the Passover meal, the traditional blessing over the bread is: "Blessed are you, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who brings forth bread from the earth."

Matthew 26:26–29

- The Last Supper is important partly because of its connection to the Jewish Passover (see Exodus 12).

The steps of the Jewish liturgy for Passover are as follows:

1. Festal blessing;
2. first cup (see Luke 22:17–18);

3. eating bitter herbs (see Matt 26:23 and corresponding study note);
4. eating unleavened bread (26:26; Mark 14:22);
5. mixing the second cup;
6. reading the Passover haggadah (this is a retelling of the Exodus story, Exodus 12);
7. first part of the hallel (songs of praise, Psalms 113–114; see study note on Psalms 113–118);
8. drinking the second cup;
9. blessing and eating unleavened bread (Matt 26:26; Mark 14:22; Luke 22:19);
10. eating the Passover lamb;
11. third cup (Matt 26:27–28; Mark 14:23–24; Luke 22:20);
12. fourth cup (see Matt 26:29[?]; Mark 14:25[?]);
13. time for fellowship;
14. second part of the hallel (Psalms 115–118; see Matthew 26:30).

The New Testament stories of the Last Supper do not include every part of a typical Jewish Passover. Yet, they include the key parts that gave meaning to the early Christian celebration of the Lord's Supper or Eucharist (see 1 Corinthians 11:23–25). Jesus, the Lamb of God, is the ultimate Passover lamb and the perfect sacrifice for sin.

- this is My body ... My blood: Ever since the Protestant Reformation, there have been three main interpretations of the words of Jesus about the bread and wine:

1. Transubstantiation: The bread and wine are believed to change into the actual body and blood of Christ, while still appearing to be bread and wine.
2. Real Presence: Christ is understood to be truly present in the sacrament in a mysterious but real way that is beyond human understanding.
3. Memorial or Symbolic View: The bread and wine are seen as symbols. The act of sharing them recalls Christ's death and resurrection, and believers receive spiritual benefit through faith.

Matthew 26:27

- gave thanks: The traditional blessing for the Passover cup was "Blessed are you, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine." An early Christian version is "We give thanks to you, our Father, for the Holy Vine of David, your child, whom you revealed to us through Jesus your child; glory be to you forever" (Didache 9.2).
- The four cups of the Passover meal match the four promises in Exodus 6:6–7: two for deliverance, one for redemption (see Matthew 26:27–28), and one for fellowship (see 26:29).

Matthew 26:28

- the covenant: In God's covenant with Israel, the blood of sheep or goats was shed and put on the doorposts at Passover (Exodus 12:5, 13; 24:8). They put it on the "the sides and tops of the doorframes" (Exodus 12:7). Jesus, the sinless Lamb of God, created a new covenant with his blood (see Jeremiah 31:31). The covenant represents God's self-initiated promise to bring salvation to humanity, fulfilling the promise to the patriarch Abraham (see Genesis 12; Galatians 3:15–29; 4:12–31).
- for many for the forgiveness of sins: Jesus shed his blood as a sacrifice to forgive sins (see Jeremiah 31:31–34; Mark 14:24). Some think many means only God's chosen people, while others believe it means "all" (compare Matthew 20:28).

Matthew 26:29

- until that day: The kingdom of God began with the ministry of Jesus, but it is not yet complete. It still awaits its full completion at the end (see 1 Corinthians 15:20–28; Revelation 19–22).
- until that day when I drink it anew: Jesus describes the final completion of the kingdom as a great feast, like the Passover. This picture shows eternal fellowship with God and his people, marked by love and peace.

Matthew 26:30

when they had sung a hymn: Some people think they sang the Great Hallel (Psalm 136).

Matthew 26:31

I will strike: In Zechariah 13:7–9, a sword strikes God's partner, the Shepherd. Jesus understood this as a prophecy of his own death. From the scattered sheep, a purified group of faithful ones will emerge (Zechariah 13:8–9). In the short term, the disciples would soon scatter and deny knowing Jesus (Matthew 26:34, 56, 69–75).

Matthew 26:32

Jesus prophesied a time when the disciples would return, even though they were about to leave him (see chapter Matthew 28; John 21).

Matthew 26:35

Peter's denial is the most well-known. But all the other disciples also left Jesus or avoided being connected with him (see 26:56).

Matthew 26:36

Gethsemane is an olive orchard about 229 meters (about 250 yards) east of Jerusalem's Golden Gate. It is above the Kidron Valley on the Mount of Olives. Jesus and his disciples often met there (Luke 22:39–40; John 18:1–2).

Matthew 26:36–46

This scene reveals how deeply Jesus understood the suffering he would encounter on the cross. It also reveals his complete dedication to God's will (see Matthew 20:28). The words in 26:41–42 echo the Lord's Prayer in 6:9–13.

Matthew 26:37

- He took with Him Peter and the two sons of Zebedee: Peter, James, and John were probably the leaders of the apostles. They received special revelation (Peter, James, and John were present at the Transfiguration, where they saw Jesus transformed on the mountain, Matthew 17:1–13). They stayed with Jesus during this difficult time.
- Jesus felt sorrow and distress as he thought about the Father's plan for him (see Matthew 27:45–46). Though he had never sinned, Jesus would take on humanity's sin so that people could become "the righteousness of God" in Jesus (2 Corinthians 5:21).

Matthew 26:38

consumed with sorrow: See John 12:27; compare with Psalms 42:5–6, 11; 43:5.

Matthew 26:39

- if it is possible: Jesus desired to obey the Father fully while dreading the suffering and judgment he was about to bear.
- Yet not as I will, but as You will: He continued to do the Father's will (Matthew 4:1–11; 16:23; John 6:38).

Matthew 26:49

kissed Him: Judas used a sign of friendship to betray Jesus. This makes his betrayal even worse.

Matthew 26:51

one of Jesus' companions: This was Peter (John 18:26).

Matthew 26:53

twelve legions: Jesus used Roman military language to describe the help he could receive from God. A legion was about 6,000 soldiers. Jesus was not a helpless victim. He allowed his own arrest.

Matthew 26:54

If Jesus had resisted, it would have blocked the fulfillment of God's saving work (see Matthew 16:21–23).

Matthew 26:55

The leaders acted secretly because they feared the people who honored Jesus (see Matthew 21:26, 46; 26:3–5).

Matthew 26:56

- We do not know which of the Scriptures Jesus was referring to. It might have been Isaiah 53 or the general Old Testament theme of a suffering Messiah.
- As Jesus had predicted earlier that evening, all the disciples adandoned him (Matthew 26:31–35).

Matthew 26:57–68

This hearing was probably an informal meeting to agree on the charges. The Jewish leaders faced pressure to keep the hearing secret to avoid a riot (see Matthew 21:26, 46; 26:5, 55; John 11:45–53).

Matthew 26:57–27.26

The Gospels describe Jesus having five legal hearings:

1. an informal hearing with Annas (John 18:13–24);
2. a night hearing with the Sanhedrin (Matthew 26:59–66);
3. a morning hearing with the Sanhedrin (Matthew 27:1–2);
4. a hearing with Herod Antipas (Luke 23:6–12); and
5. a two-part trial with Pilate (Matthew 27:11–31; see Luke 23:6–12).

These hearings form two main trials, a Jewish trial and a Roman trial.

Matthew 26:58

the courtyard of the high priest: This place indicates an unplanned meeting of the Sanhedrin at the high priest's palace (Matthew 26:3).

Matthew 26:59

were seeking false testimony: The verb tense suggests a long and possibly desperate attempt to find any testimony to support a formal accusation (see Mark 14:55–56).

Matthew 26:60

they did not find any: This was because the evidence was too weak or inconsistent to seek a death sen-

tence. This changed when two men gave testimonies that matched (Deuteronomy 17:6; 19:15).

Matthew 26:61

The charge was either a misunderstanding or a deliberate misrepresentation of what Jesus had said about his death and resurrection (see John 2:19–21).

Matthew 26:63

if You are the Christ: The high priest asked this because Zechariah 6:12 prophesied that the Christ (Messiah) would rebuild the temple (compare Matthew 26:61).

Matthew 26:64

- You have said it yourself: This was a careful but clear "yes" (see Matthew 26:25; 27:11). In Mark's account Jesus answers, "I Am" (Mark 14:62).
- you will see: By quoting Daniel 7:13, Jesus confirmed he was the Son of Man who God would vindicate and honor.
- sitting at the right hand of Power: See Psalm 110:1. Jews often avoided saying God's name directly (see study note on Matthew 5:4).
- The phrase coming on the clouds of heaven might refer to the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 or to the return of Jesus at the end of history.

Matthew 26:65

He has blasphemed: Caiaphas thought Jesus had spoken against God (blasphemed) when Jesus claimed to be the Son of Man. The title "Son of Man" was very special. It described someone who shared God's glory and power (Daniel 7:13–14).

Matthew 26:67–68

This abuse fulfills the prophecies in Isaiah 50:6 and 53:4–9. Jesus himself prophesied these things (Matthew 16:21; 17:22–23; 20:18–19; 26:2; see also Mark 14:65).

Matthew 26:69–75

Peter's denials fulfill what Jesus prophesied (Matthew 26:34).

Matthew 26:73

your accent: Jews from Galilee spoke with a distinct accent compared to those from Judea (see Matthew 4:13 and the related study note).

Matthew 26:75

The crow of the rooster reminded Peter of what Jesus predicted would happen (26:34). Peter felt deep sorrow.

Matthew 27:1

The Jewish leaders said Jesus had spoken blasphemy (26:65–66). That charge was enough for the death penalty under Jewish law, but it would not persuade a Roman judge. So the leading priests and elders worked together to create a political charge that would fit Roman law on capital offenses (see 27:11–26; Luke 23:2).

Matthew 27:1–2

The Jewish leaders prepared charges against Jesus so that Pilate would order his death. Pilate, a Gentile, fulfills the prediction of Jesus from Matthew 20:19.

Matthew 27:2

Tiberius Caesar made Pilate the governor (or prefect) of Judea. Pilate mainly governed from Caesarea, not Jerusalem, from AD 26 to AD 36. Although he had full power in Judea, Pilate answered to the governor (or legate) of Syria. This man was the main authority in the eastern Roman Empire. The Jewish historian Josephus records several mentions of Pilate. Pilate's disrespect for the holiness of Jewish customs caused revolts.

Matthew 27:3

Judas felt deep remorse (the Greek word metamelomai), but he did not repent (the Greek word metanoeō). Repentance would have changed his heart and led to obedience and a relationship with God through faith.

Matthew 27:3–10

There are two stories about Judas's death. This one and the one found in Acts 1:18–19. There are differences between the two stories:

1. Matthew says the priests bought the field (Matthew 27:6–7), but Acts suggests Judas bought it (Acts 1:18).
2. Matthew says Judas hanged himself by hanging (Matthew 27:5). Acts says he fell and his body burst open (Acts 1:18).
3. Matthew says the field of blood was named for its use as a burial place (Matthew 27:7–8). Acts says it was named because of Judas's violent death (Acts 1:19).

The stories can align if Acts describes the results of Matthew's events.

Matthew 27:4

innocent blood: The innocence of Jesus is a key theme in the story of his suffering (see Matthew 23:35; 26:55–56, 59–60; 27:18–19, 24; see also Luke 23:47).

Matthew 27:5

hanged himself: Judas killed himself because he felt guilty but did not repent. His death also matched the Old Testament law about punishing a false witness (see Deuteronomy 19:16–21).

Matthew 27:7

foreigners: These were non-Jewish people who died in Jerusalem. If they could not find the owner of donated money, they used it for public charity. In this case, they used money considered ceremonially unclean to buy a ceremonially unclean place for people considered ceremonially unclean.

Matthew 27:8

Field of Blood: This is another way of describing a cemetery (compare Acts 1:18–19).

Matthew 27:9–10

- what was spoken through Jeremiah the prophet was fulfilled: The quote is from Zechariah 11:12–13. Matthew might have followed the Jewish tradition of naming books by the first book in the scroll. In this case, Jeremiah would be the first book in the scroll containing Zechariah. Or, Matthew might be referencing similar passages in Jeremiah (Jeremiah 19:1–13; 18:2–6; 32:6–15) along with Zechariah 11:12–13.
- Matthew notices a strong similarity between Zechariah's actions and those of the leading priests. Both situations involve rejecting God's messenger, who was meant to be the king of God's people.

Matthew 27:11

King of the Jews: The Sanhedrin's first charge of blasphemy in Matthew 26:65–66; 27:1 did not cause concern for the Romans. The Romabs considered it to be a Jewish religious issue (see Acts 25:18–20). So, the Sanhedrin changed the charge to make Jesus seem like a political rebel to the Romans (see Luke 23:2).

Matthew 27:11–26

The Roman trial included an initial hearing before Pilatee (Matthew 27:11–14), then one before Herod Antipas (Luke 23:6–16), and a second hearing with Pilate (Matthew 27:15–26).

Matthew 27:15

Pilate's behavior seems unusual. It was not normal for him to try to please his Jewish subjects. But Pilate's relationship with Caesar might have been unstable at this time (see study note on John 19:12; see Philo, On the Embassy to Gaius 159–161). If so, this gesture might have been to maintain peace and avoid negative attention from Rome.

Matthew 27:16

notorious prisoner named Barabbas: He is also called an "insurrectionist" (Mark 15:7; John 18:40). This word can also mean a robber or someone who led a revolt (see Luke 23:19). To the zealots, Barabbas was considered a hero.

Matthew 27:19

have suffered terribly in a dream (compare Matthew 1:20): It is notable that a pagan woman recognized Jesus innocence and spoke up for him, while the Jewish crowd did not.

Matthew 27:24

You bear the responsibility: The priests told Judas the same thing (Matthew 27:4).

Matthew 27:25

- All the people (see 21:43): This does not mean every living Jewish person. Instead, it refers to those who urged the condemnation of Jesus. They represented all of Israel who disbelieved Jesus. Their actions led to consequences for the entire nation, like the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70.
- His blood be on us and on our children! (see 23:35; 2 Samuel 1:16; 14:9; Jeremiah 51:35; Acts 5:28; 18:6; 20:26): Some Christians have misunderstood and misused this verse as a basis for persecuting Jews. But it is not a general accusation against all Jewish people.

Matthew 27:26

When the Romans flogged a man, they beat him with whips that had leather straps on the end. Some straps had sharp bone, lead, or rock pieces attached (see also Deuteronomy 25:1–3; 1 Kings 12:11, 14; Acts 16:22; 22:25; 2 Corinthians 11:24–25).

Matthew 27:27

- the governor's soldiers were extra troops recruited from non-Jewish residents of Palestine.
- The soldiers stayed at the governor's official building in Jerusalem. This building was called the Antonia Fortress. It stood at the northwest corner of the Temple area.

Matthew 27:27–31

During the Jewish trial, people mocked Jesus as a prophet (Matthew 26:67–68). Here, they mocked him as a king.

Matthew 27:28–29

- The scarlet robe was probably a soldier's cloak used to imitate royal clothing in order to mock Jesus.
- Weaving a crown of thorns was meant to mock Jesus as a king.

Matthew 27:32

Usually, the person to be crucified would carry their own cross. They only carried the crossbeam since the vertical pole was already at the crucifixion site. The Romans might have forced Simon to help because Jesus was weak from being whipped. Making Simon help could also have been a way to mock Jesus. They treated him like someone who deserved a servant, even though they led him to his death.

Matthew 27:32–44

The crowd mocked Jesus, but their words were still true. He is the Son of God, the King of Israel, and the Messiah.

Matthew 27:34

- They probably gave Jesus wine mixed with bitter gall to ridicule him (see Psalm 69:21). It also was a sedative. Jesus probably refused it so he could fully experience suffering for our sins (see Isaiah 53:10).
- Gall is another name sometimes given to wormwood. It is a very bitter substance made from the oil of the Artemisia plant, sometimes used as medicine in the ancient world (compare Mark 15:23).

Matthew 27:35

they had crucified Him: Crucifixion (being nailed to a cross) was not common among Jews. But it was a widespread Roman punishment for military and political offenders. This was especially true for slaves, rebels, and insurrectionists (rioters). The extreme cruelty and public display of crucifixion was a strong warning to society.

The Romans would flog victims (beat them with whips). Then they would crucify the victims naked. This added to their humiliation. Most considered it the most painful death possible. It involved intense suffering, exposure to weather and insects, and suffocation. It often concluded with a final violent spear thrust to end life.

Since the Law said that anyone hung on a tree was under God's curse (Deuteronomy 21:22–23), crucifixion was especially offensive to the Jewish people. Yet in God's plan, what humans saw as shameful became the very means of salvation. Earlier, Jesus had told his disciples to take up their cross and follow him (Matthew 16:24).

Matthew 27:37

The Romans would fasten the official crime to the cross above the head of the offender. They accused Jesus of political rebellion.

Matthew 27:38

Jesus was crucified between two convicted revolutionaries. This increased his shame and made him appear guilty by association (linked with rebels).

Matthew 27:40

If You are the Son of God: This taunt reminds us of when the devil tempted Jesus at the start of his public ministry (Matthew 4:1–11). The devil tried to use the special status of Jesus to tempt him to avoid suffering (see also 16:21–23).

Matthew 27:45

darkness: This represents God's judgment. Or, it could more specifically refer to the coming of the day of the Lord (see Amos 5:18, 20; 8:9–10; also Jeremiah 4:27–28; 13:16; 15:9).

Matthew 27:46

- Eli, Eli: This cry means My God, My God. The sound of these words may have made some people think Jesus was calling for Elijah (Matthew 27:47).
- My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?: Jesus was expressing the weight of judgment he bore for humanity's sin.

Matthew 27:47

Many Jews believed Elijah would return before the day of the Lord (Matthew 11:14–15; 17:10–13; Malachi 4:5).

Matthew 27:48

The sour wine was vinegar. The drink was probably meant to mock Jesus by pretending to ease his thirst (compare Psalm 69:21 with Matthew 27:34). Although some scholars think they offered it as a genuine act of kindness.

Matthew 27:50

- Each of the four gospels focuses on different parts of the final moments of Jesus.
- He yielded up His spirit: Jesus gave up his life willingly. This shows his authority, since he chose the moment of his own death (see also John 19:30).
- Jesus had cried out again (see Matthew 27:46): This final loud cry was the last prayer of Jesus (see Luke 23:46).

Matthew 27:51

- The tearing of the temple curtain is symbolic. It means that that the wall dividing people from God has been torn down by the death of Jesus (see also Ephesians 2:11–22; Hebrews 6:19; 9:1–10:25).
- The earth quaked and the rocks were split: These are signs that judgment has come (see Exodus 19:18; Judges 5:4; Psalm 18:7; Joel 3:14–17; Amos 8:8–10). The Jewish historian Josephus records that around AD 30, a star resembling a sword appeared and the temple gates opened by themselves (Josephus, War 6.5.3–4).

Matthew 27:52–53

- The tombs broke open: At the moment of the death of Jesus, God's kingdom broke into the world in a new way. His death destroyed the power of death and began the promise of final resurrection (see Isaiah 26:19; Daniel 12:2; 1 Corinthians 15:1–58; Colossians 1:18; Hebrews 2:14–15).
- Some holy people were raised to life. But they may not have entered Jerusalem until after Jesus rose from the dead. Another view is that they were not raised until after the resurrection of Jesus, since Jesus is the "firstfruits" (the first to be raised, showing what will come for others; see 1 Corinthians 15:20, 23; Colossians 1:18). If this second view is correct, Matthew included the story to show the great impact of the death of Jesus.

Matthew 27:54

- The Roman officer and the other soldiers were not Jewish.
- the Son of God: This could be a clear statement that Jesus is the unique Son of God (see Matthew 14:33; 16:16) or perhaps a general statement about the innocence of Jesus (see Luke 23:47). They reacted to the earthquake and everything that happened as signs of divine involvement in this event.

Matthew 27:58

- In Roman crucifixion, the bodies of criminals were often left on the cross until they rotted. Jewish law, however, did not allow this. Deuteronomy 21:22–23 forbids leaving a body on a cross or gallows overnight. Joseph of Arimathea acted in line with this law when he asked for the body of Jesus. His request also showed his loyalty to Jesus.
- Pilate ordered: Pilate agreed to Joseph's request and gave the order. He likely did this because he did not believe Jesus was guilty of rebellion against Rome (see Matthew 27:24–26).

Matthew 27:59–60

- Burial customs were important in Judaism, unlike the Greeks and Romans who cremated their dead. Jews considered leaving a body unburied to be a severe punishment (Deuteronomy 21:22–23; 2 Kings 9:37; Psalm 79:3; Jeremiah 16:4, 6; Ezekiel 29:5; Revelation 11:9).

People mourned and lamented death (Mark 5:38–39). They washed the body (Acts 9:37). They anointed the body (Matt 26:6–13; John 12:3, 7; 19:39). And they wrapped the body in burial cloths (Matthew 27:59; see Genesis 50:2–3). Then they placed the body in a tomb (Matthew 23:27). This tomb was either tunneled into rock or carved into a cave wall. A large stone often sealed the tomb to prevent ceremonial uncleanness or stealing.

- clean linen ... new tomb: These terms symbolize ceremonial purity. Joseph of Arimathea bought the tomb for his family, but had not used it.

Matthew 27:62–66

This event supports the truth of Jesus resurrection. It is very unlikely that Matthew invented the story, because many witnesses were alive who could have denied it.

Matthew 28:1

Mary Magdalene (see Matthew 27:56): Mentioning two women as witnesses adds credibility to the story. In those times, people considered the testimony of a woman less reliable than a man. So a someone making up a false story would not have chosen women as witnesses.

Matthew 28:1–10

The four gospels each emphasize different aspects of the empty tomb and resurrection appearances. Matthew focuses on three things:

1. the reunion of Jesus and his disciples in Galilee,
2. the Jewish leaders' attempt to discredit the resurrection, and
3. the importance of the ressurection for the salvation of the world.

Matthew 28:12

- Such a bribe was against the law (see Exodus 20:16; 23:8).
- elders: See the study note on Matthew 21:23.

Matthew 28:13

stole him away: Stealing from tombs was common in ancient times. So this accusation would have been easy to believe.

Matthew 28:15

And this account has been circulated among the Jews to this very day: Around AD 165, the early church father Justin Martyr wrote to the Jews of his time. He wrote, "You have sent . . . men throughout all the world to proclaim, 'A godless and lawless heresy has sprung from one Jesus, a Galilean deceiver, whom we crucified, but his disciples stole him by night from the tomb . . . and now [the disciples] deceive men by asserting that he has risen from the dead and ascended into heaven'" (Justin Martyr, Dialogue with Trypho 108).

This false information probably increased after the disciples began preaching about the resurrection of Jesus (see Acts 2:22–36).

Matthew 28:17

some doubted: This could refer to Thomas (John 20:24–29). But all eleven disciples might have experienced mixed feelings of worship and doubt (see also Matt 14:31; Luke 24:10–11; John 20:24–29).

Matthew 28:18

The authority of Jesus comes from the power given to him by the Father (see Matthew 7:29; 9:6–8; 21:23–27; 26:64; John 3:35).

Matthew 28:19

- go and (literally going): This is a command to make disciples. Matthew likely meant "go" as a separate command, not just as "while you go"(compare similar uses in Matthew 9:6; Acts 10:20).
- make disciples: A disciple turns from sin, trusts Jesus for salvation, and obeys his teachings.
- all nations: The gospel mission to non-Jewish (Gentile) people officially started here (see Matthew 10:5–6; 15:24; also 1:1; 2:1–12; 8:5–13; 21:43; 24:14; 26:13).
- Two parts of making disciples are baptizing and teaching (Matthew 28:20). Baptism is a public identification with Jesus and submission to him and his work of salvation (see 3:13–17; 10:32–33; 20:28; 26:28; Acts 2:38; Romans 6:1–11; 1 Peter 3:21).
- in the name of: This means entering a relationship and its benefits for true believers in Christ.
- Father ... Son ... Holy Spirit: This phrase shows the Christian belief that the one God is three persons (Father, Son, and Holy Spirit) known as the Trinity (see also 1 Corinthians 12:4–6; 2 Corinthians 13:14; Ephesians 4:4–6; 2 Thessalonians 2:13–14; 1 Peter 1:2; Revelation 1:4–6).

Matthew 28:20

teaching: The disciples are to teach people everything Jesus commanded, such as the Sermon on the Mount (chapters 5–7). People should recognize the church because it obeys the commands of Jesus (5:17–20; 7:13–27). The authority and presence of Jesus establish the mission of the disciples (see also 1:23; 18:20).